The AI-Powered Exodus: Migrating 100 Teams by Decoupling Tech from Truth

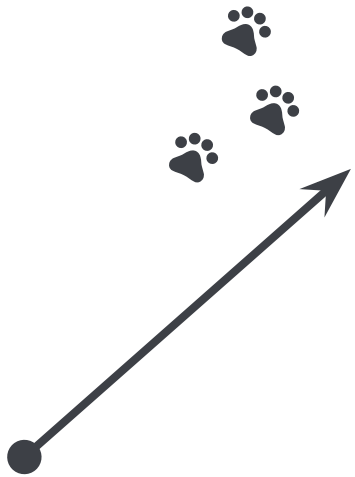
Eugene Klyuchnikov & Mukrram Ur Rahman
Zalando SE, Germany
2026-11-11

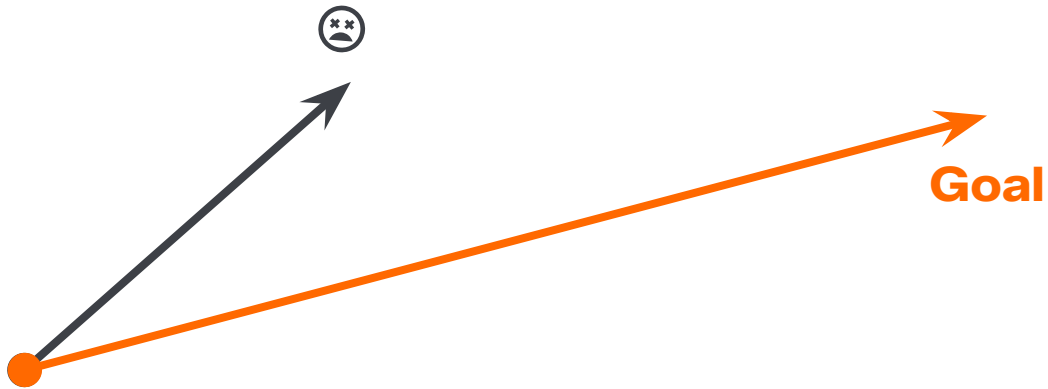


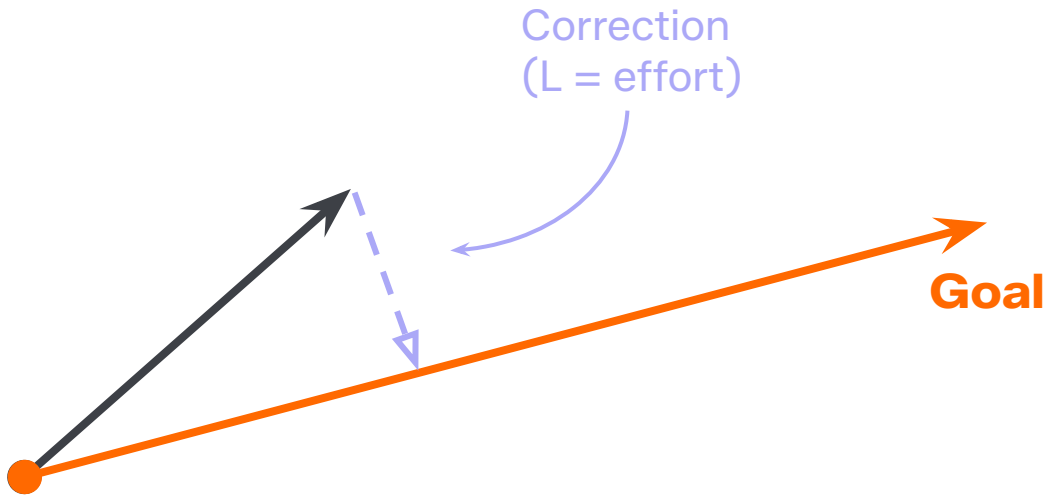
Today, we will discuss:

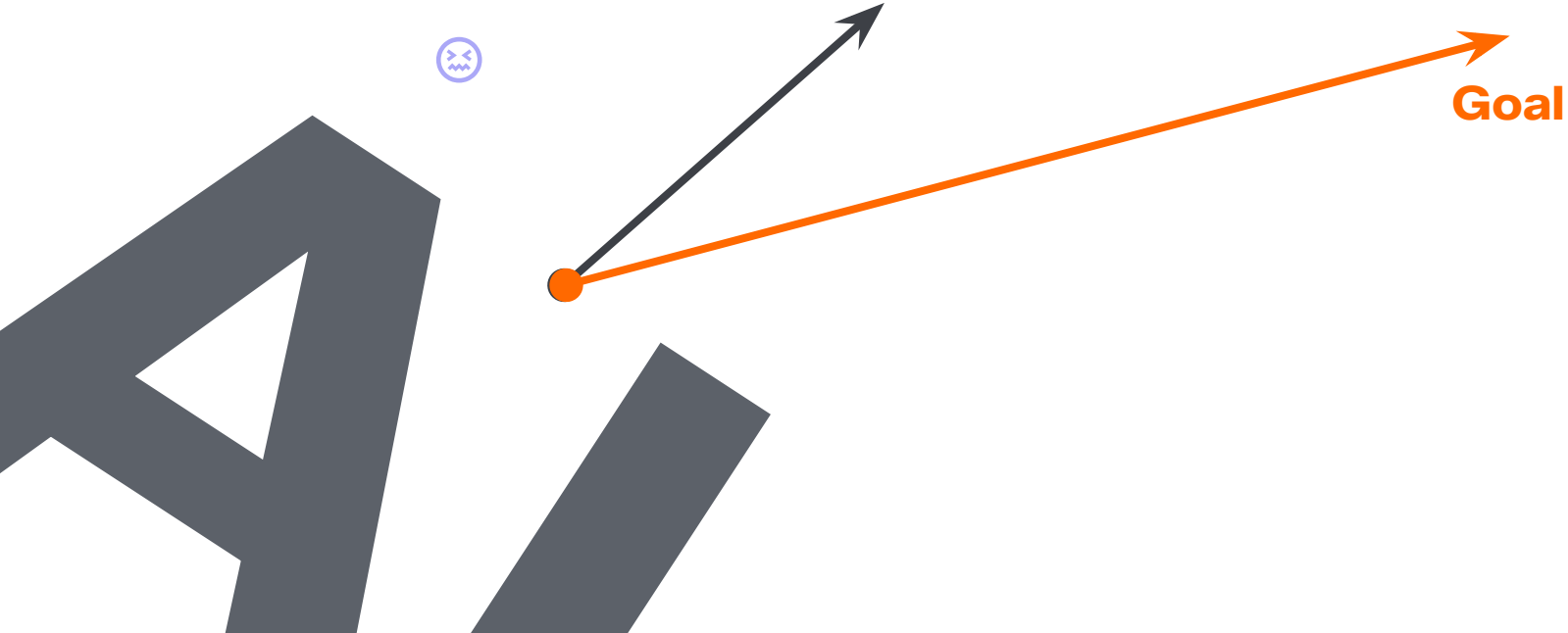
- Why most multi-team migrations fail before they even start.
- Where to solve the problem once and scale it across 100 use cases.
- How to safely kill unownable legacy without breaking production.

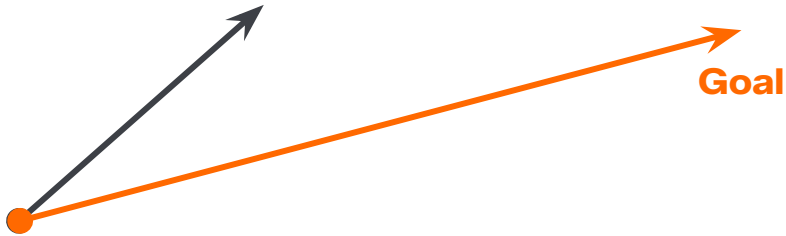


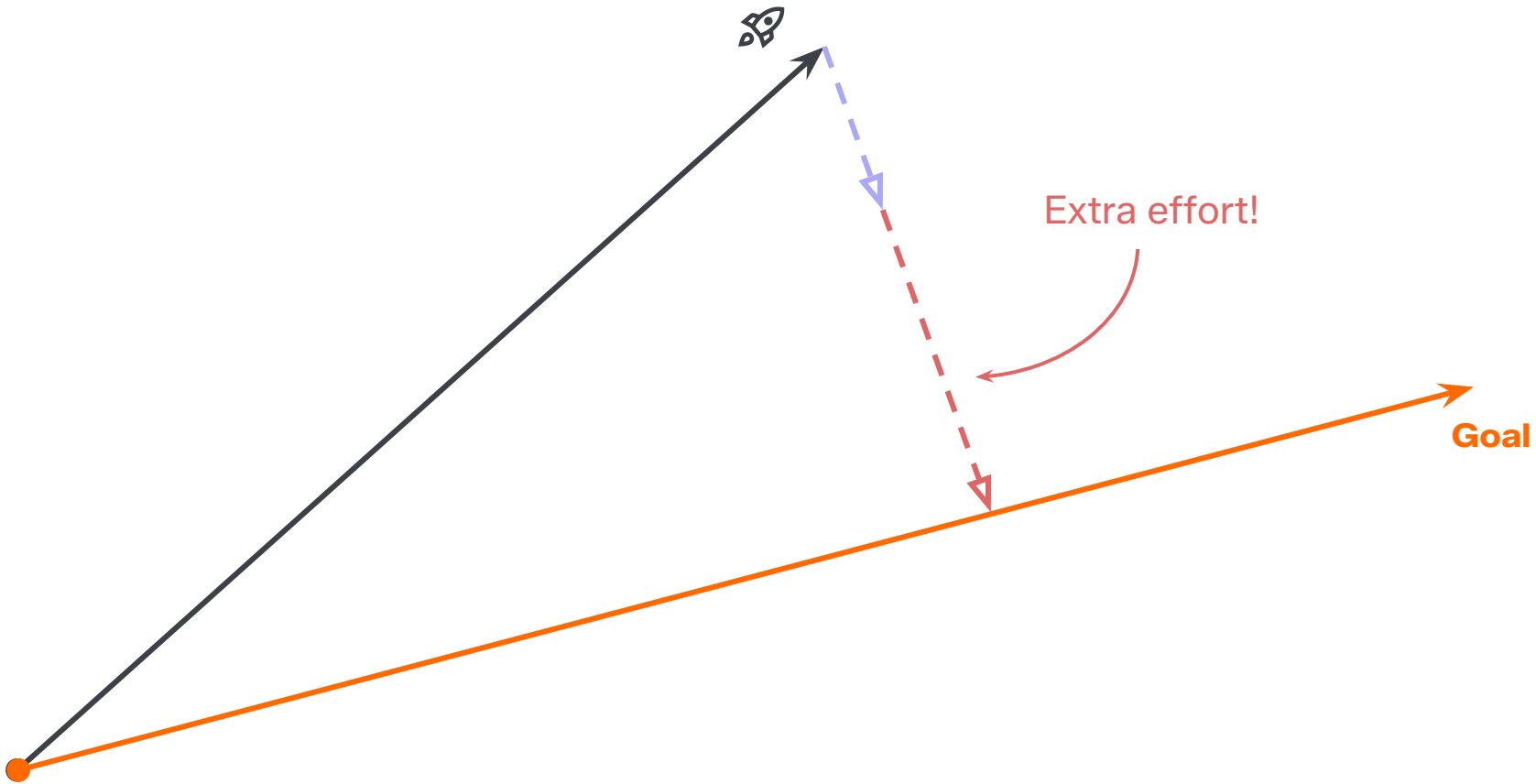


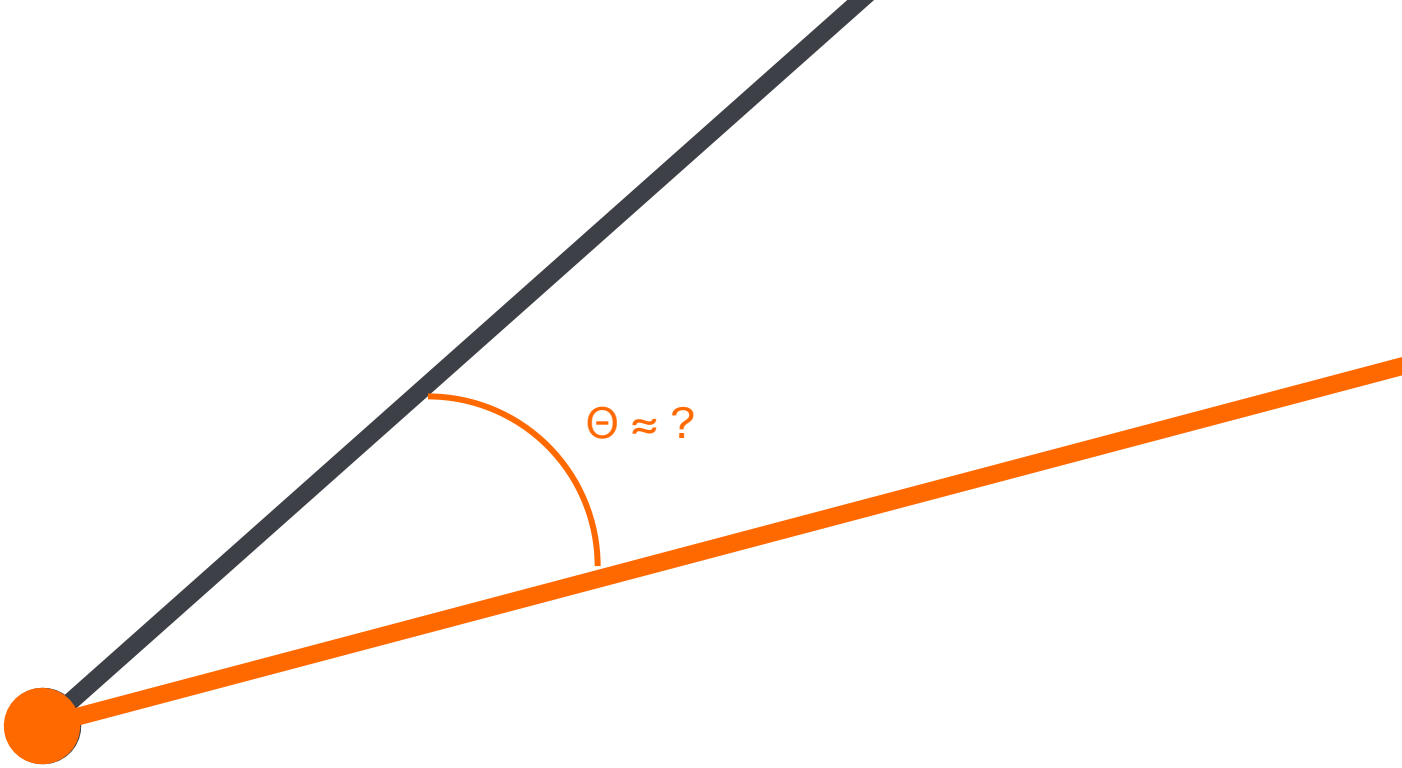

Goal


Correction
(L = effort)
Goal


Goal


Goal


Extra effort!
Goal


Θ ≈ ?

Θwnership.

Zalando:

Europe’s biggest fashion ecosystem.

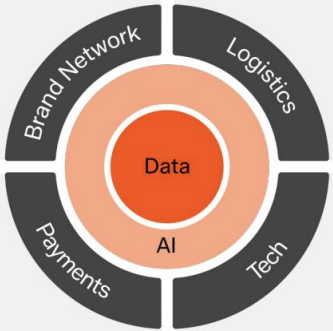
Unparalleled network of global and European brands
(selection)

>7,000
Brands across
the Zalando Group

Europe’s leading fashion fulfillment network



14
Locations serving
29 European markets[1]



Offered payment methods (selection)

Invoice · SEPA · Klarna · Apple Pay · VISA · Mastercard · PayPal · TWINT · blik · iDEAL · vipps · swish · MobilePay · Cash on delivery · Gift cards

>34bn
EUR payment volume
processed in-house
annually

~3,000
Tech talents driving innovations



Powerful in-house payments platform with E-Money license and proprietary BNPL solution

Unique and scalable proprietary tech stack for fashion and lifestyle

LEGACY TRACKING SYSTEM
(powered via Google Analytics)



Google Analytics
Event Data Generation

BigQuery
Serverless Data Warehouse



Looker Studio
Dashboards & Reporting

TRANSITION

~100
teams

~20
dashboards

~50
pipelines

~200
data objects

~2 Billion
records / day

NEW TRACKING SYSTEM
(internal development)



Databricks Unity Catalog
Storage & Governance

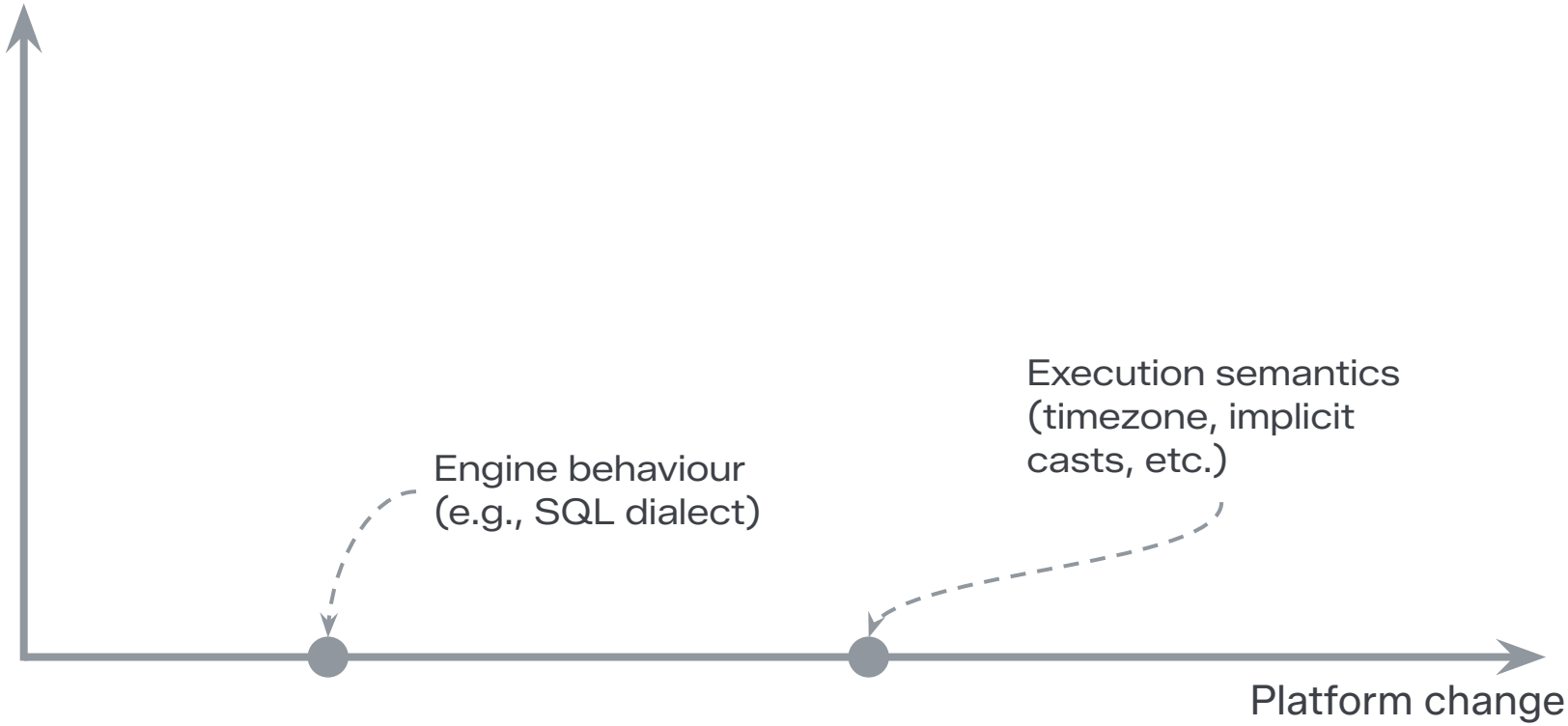


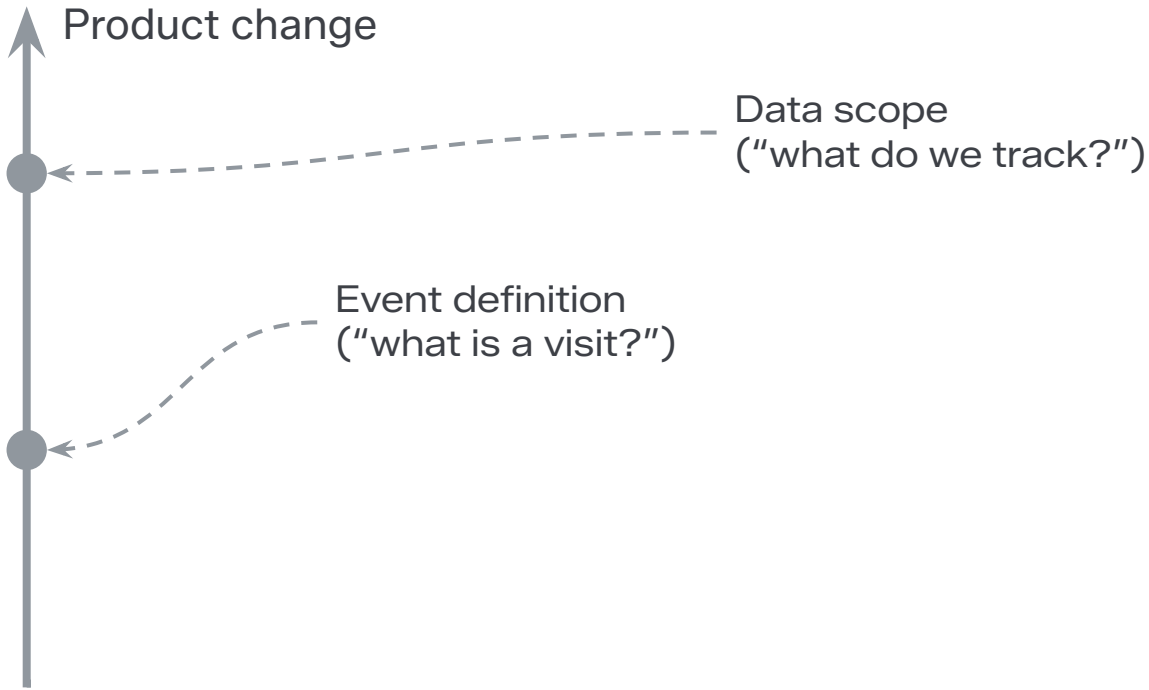
Databricks Compute
ETL, Notebooks, Jobs

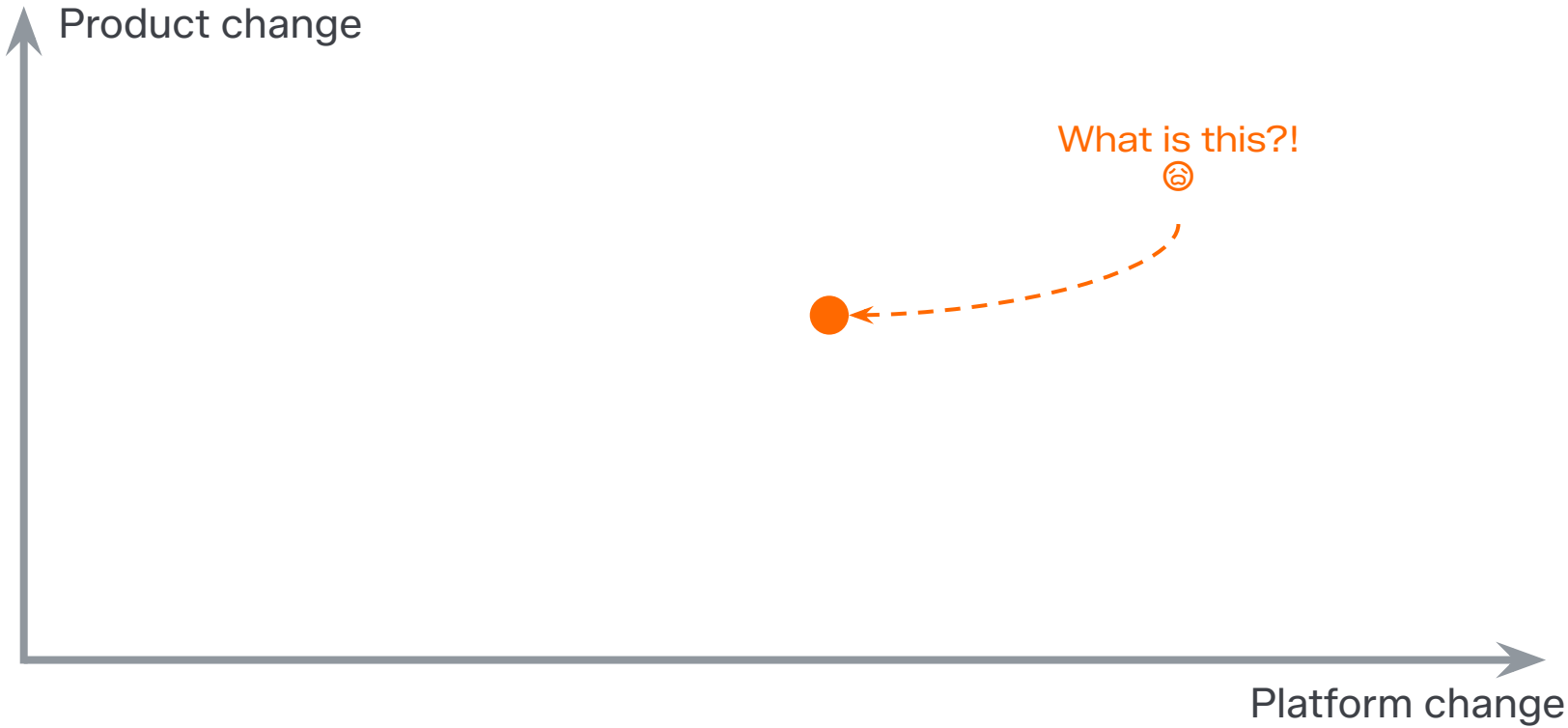


Databricks AI/BI
Dashboards & Analytics

Don’t change
the product and the platform
at the same time.


Engine behaviour
(e.g., SQL dialect)
Execution semantics
(timezone, implicit
casts, etc.)
Platform change


Product change
Data scope
(“what do we track?”)
Event definition
(“what is a visit?”)


Product change
What is this?!
Platform change

Hey (·_·),

Migrate Platform.



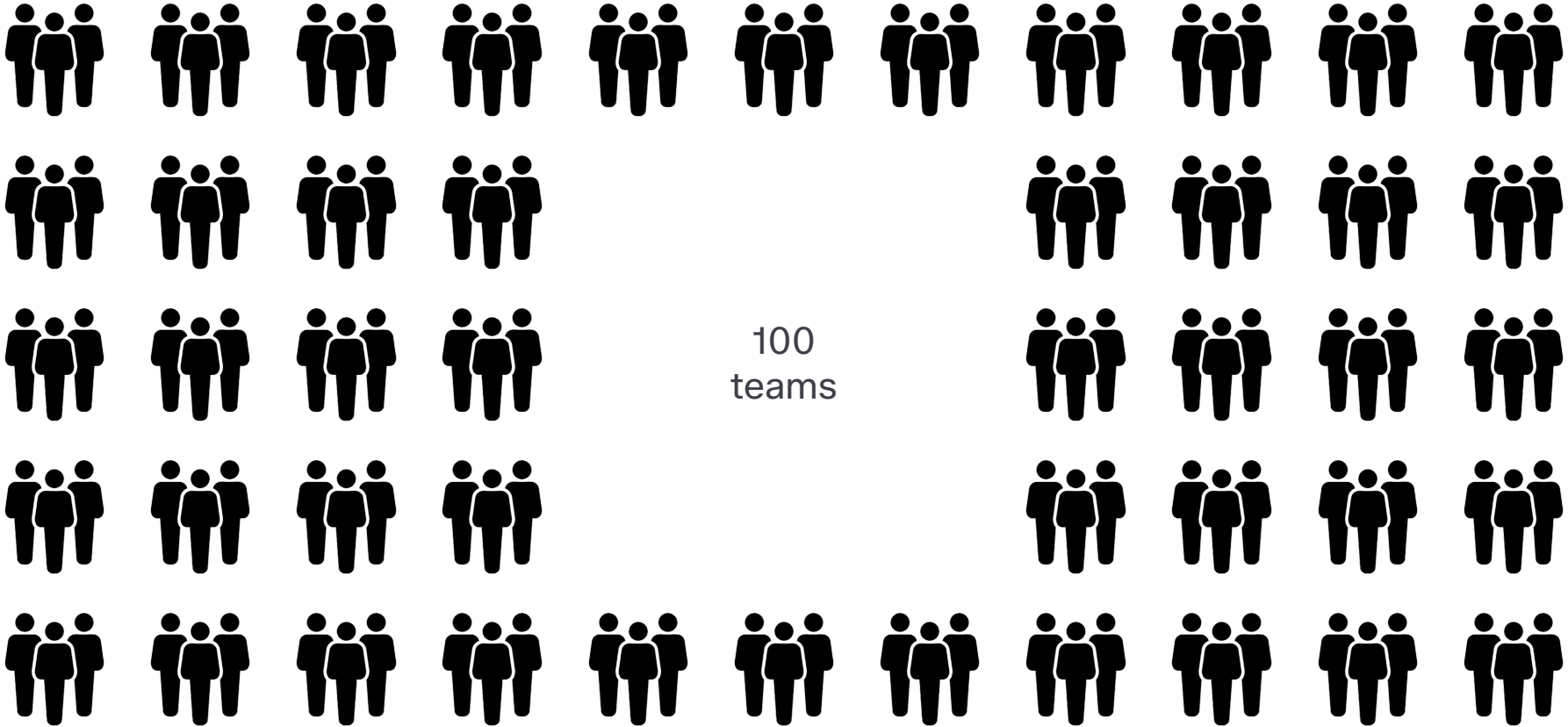
Hey (·_·),

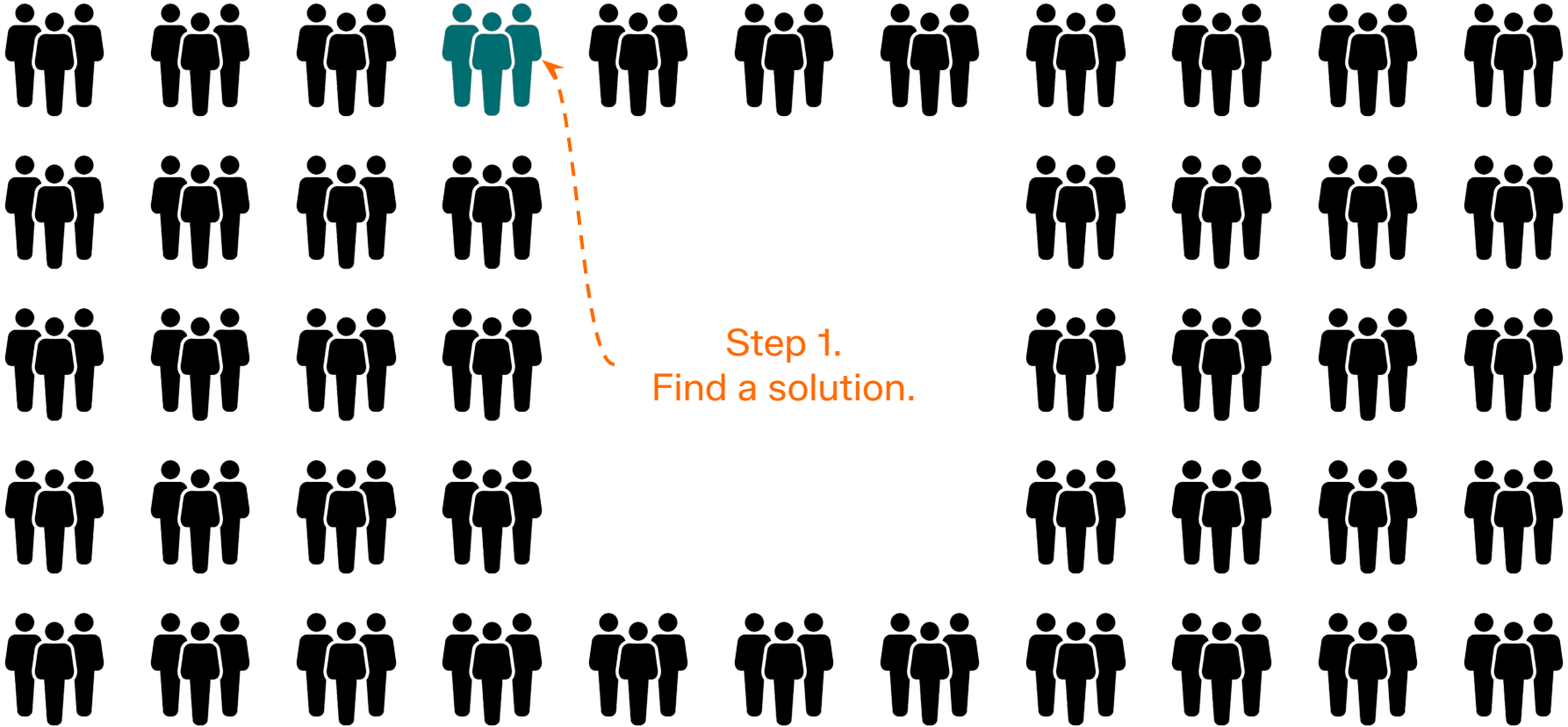
Migrate Product.

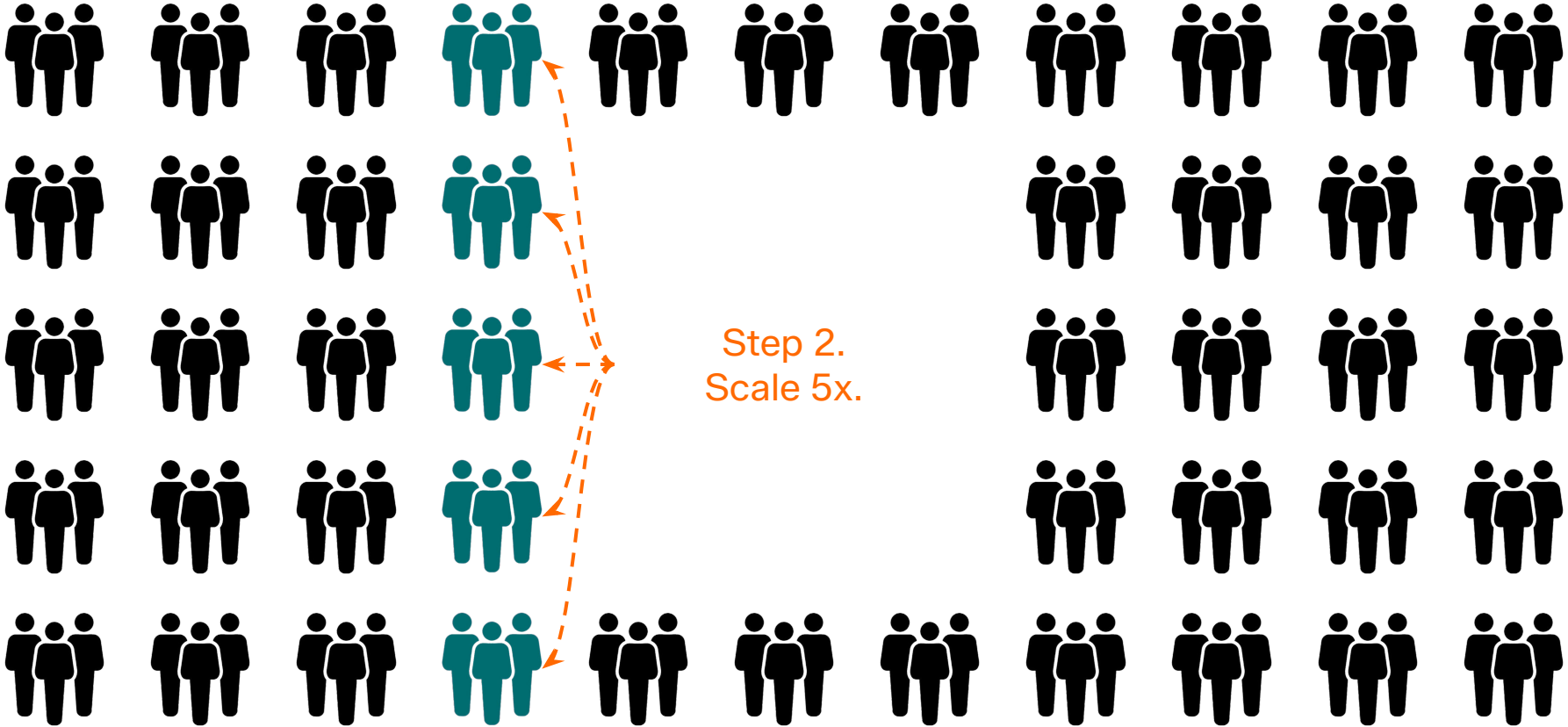
We control
the “good” direction.

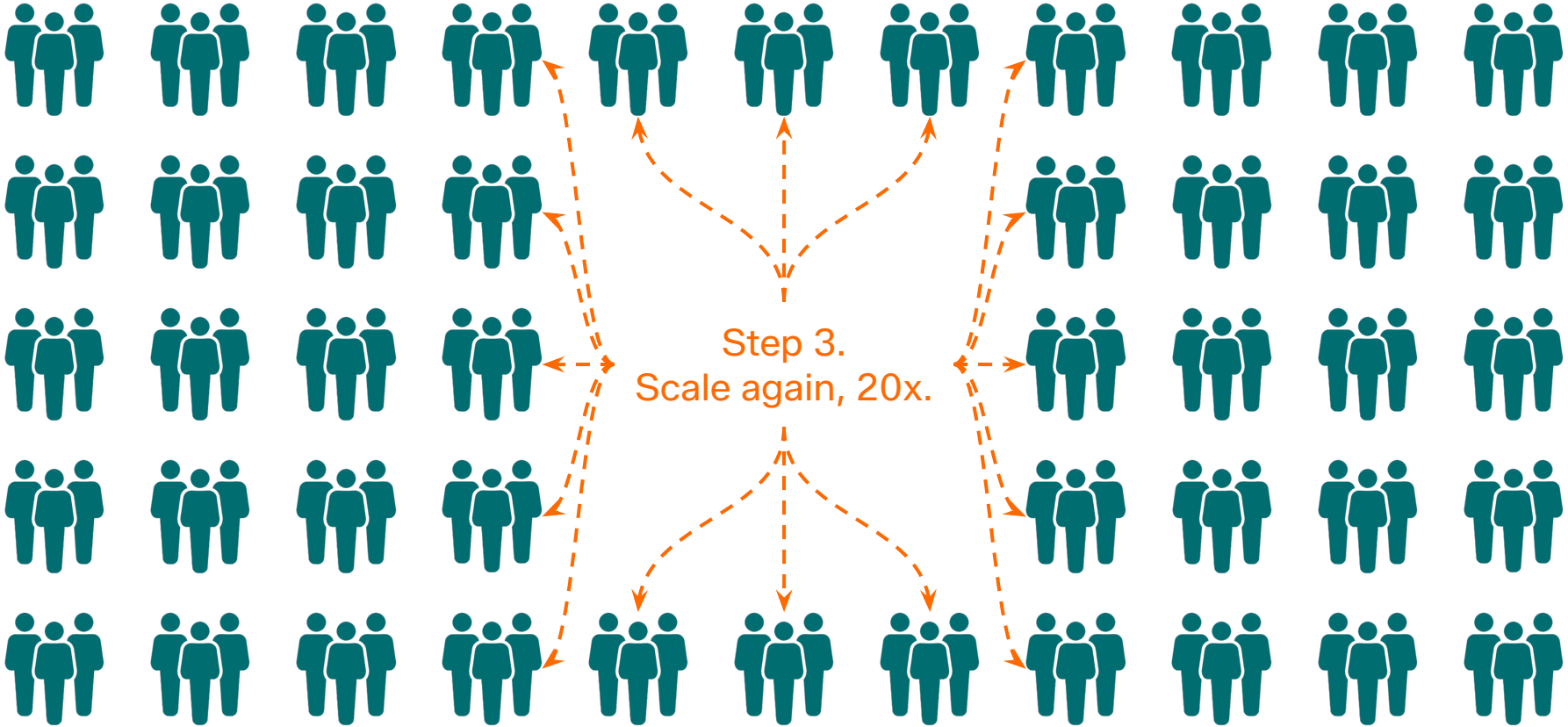
If you don't own your direction,

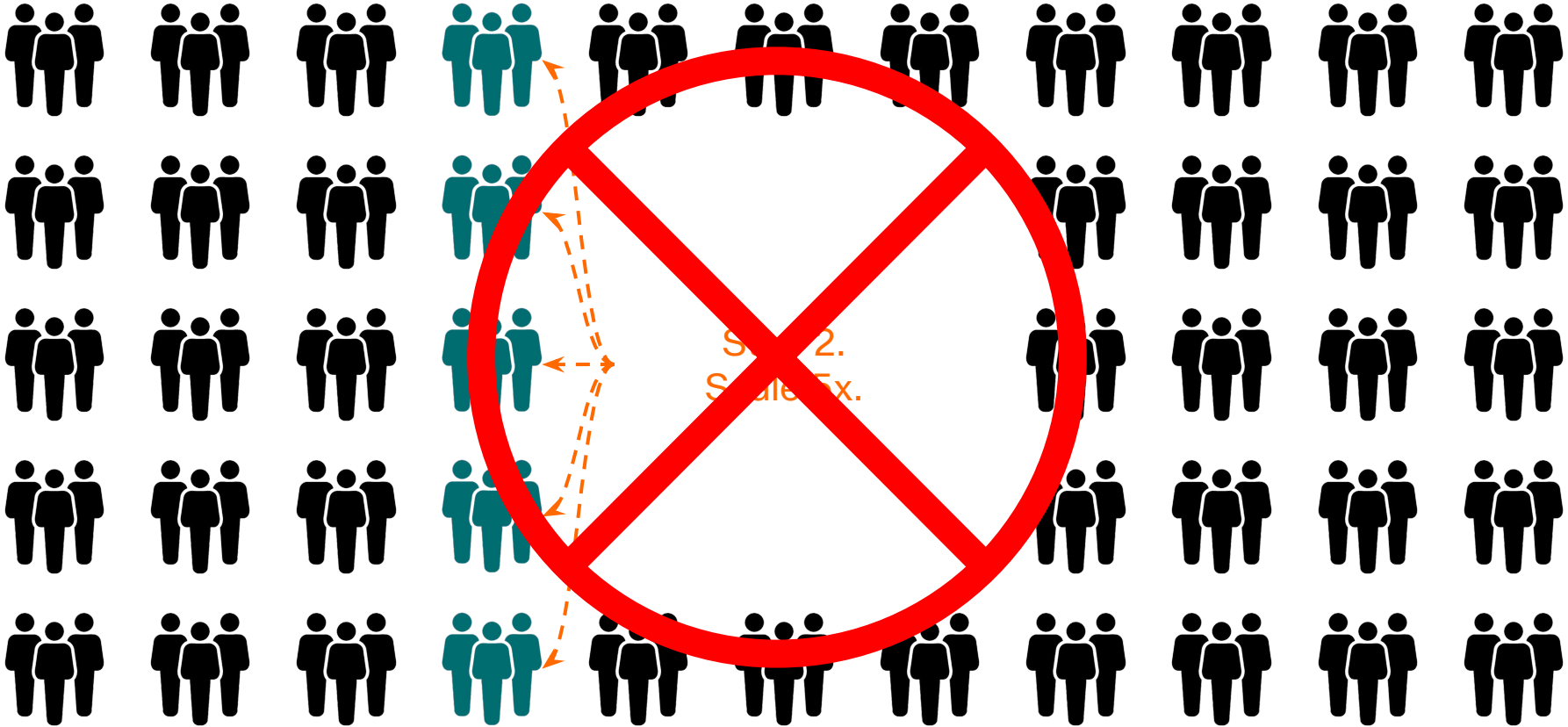
AI will happily accelerate the wrong vector.


100
teams


Step 1.
Find a solution.

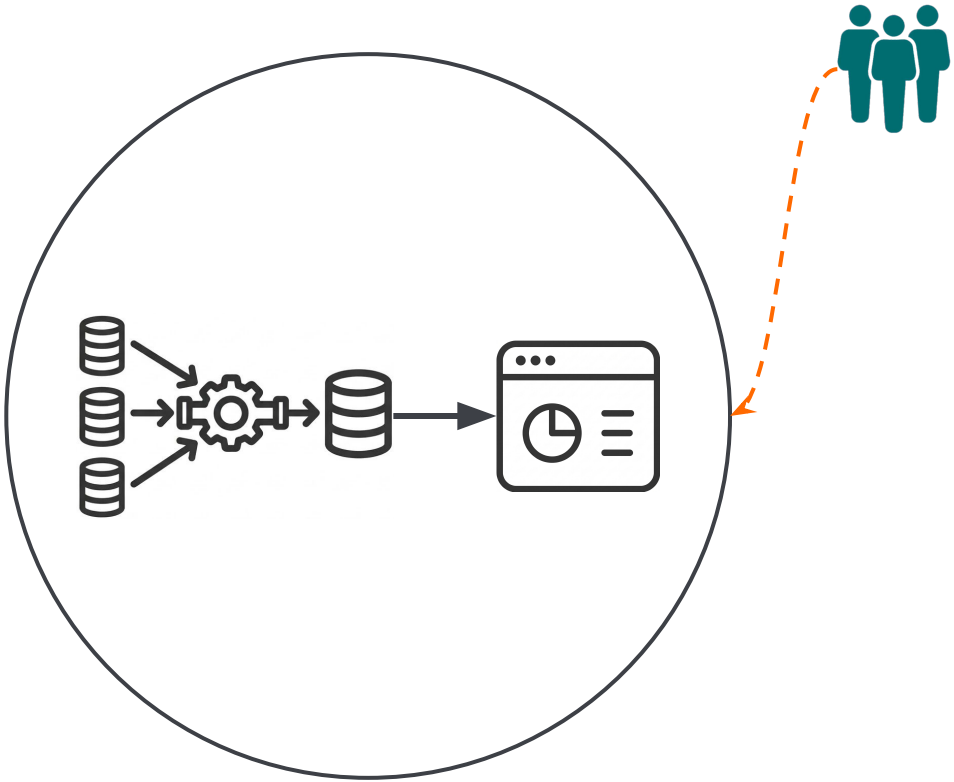

Step 2.
Scale 5x.

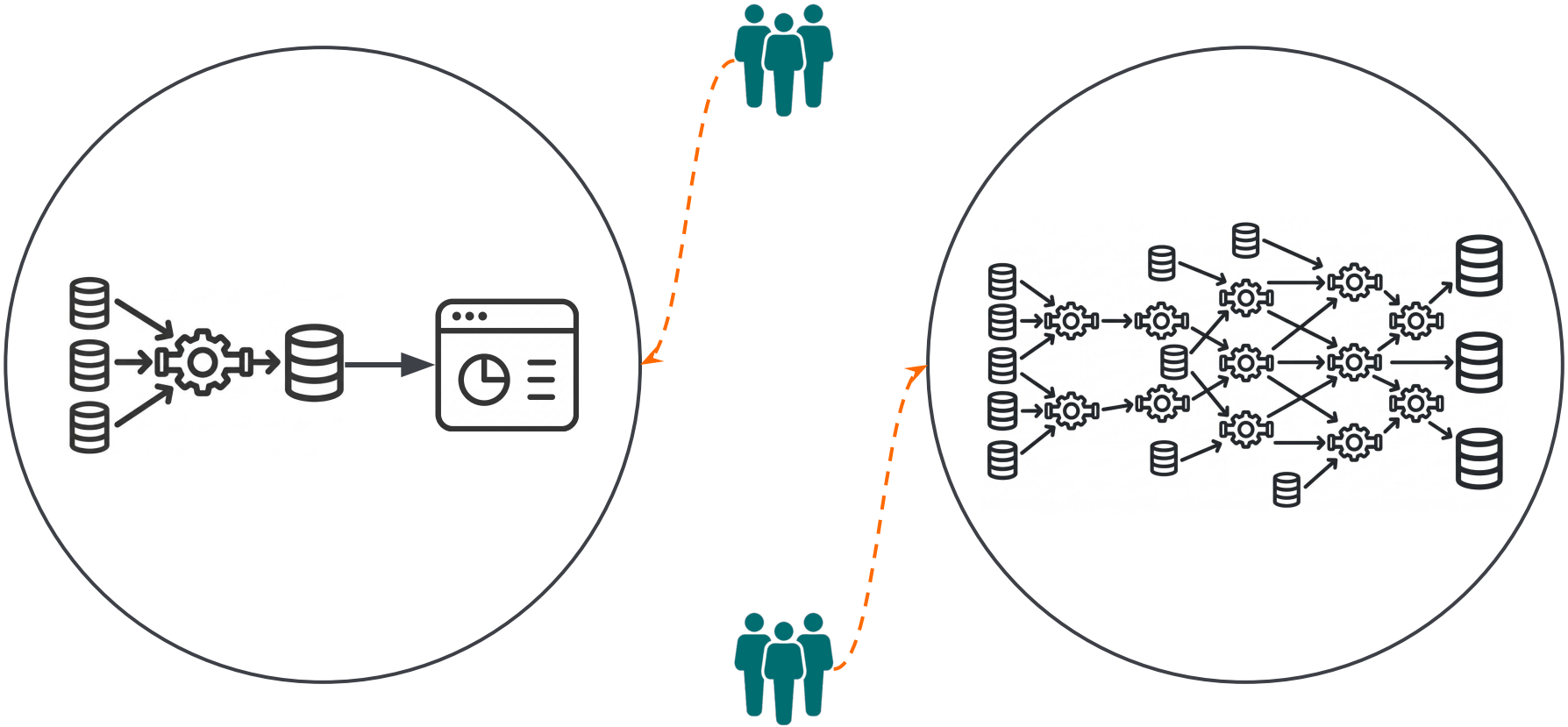

Step 3.
Scale again, 20x.

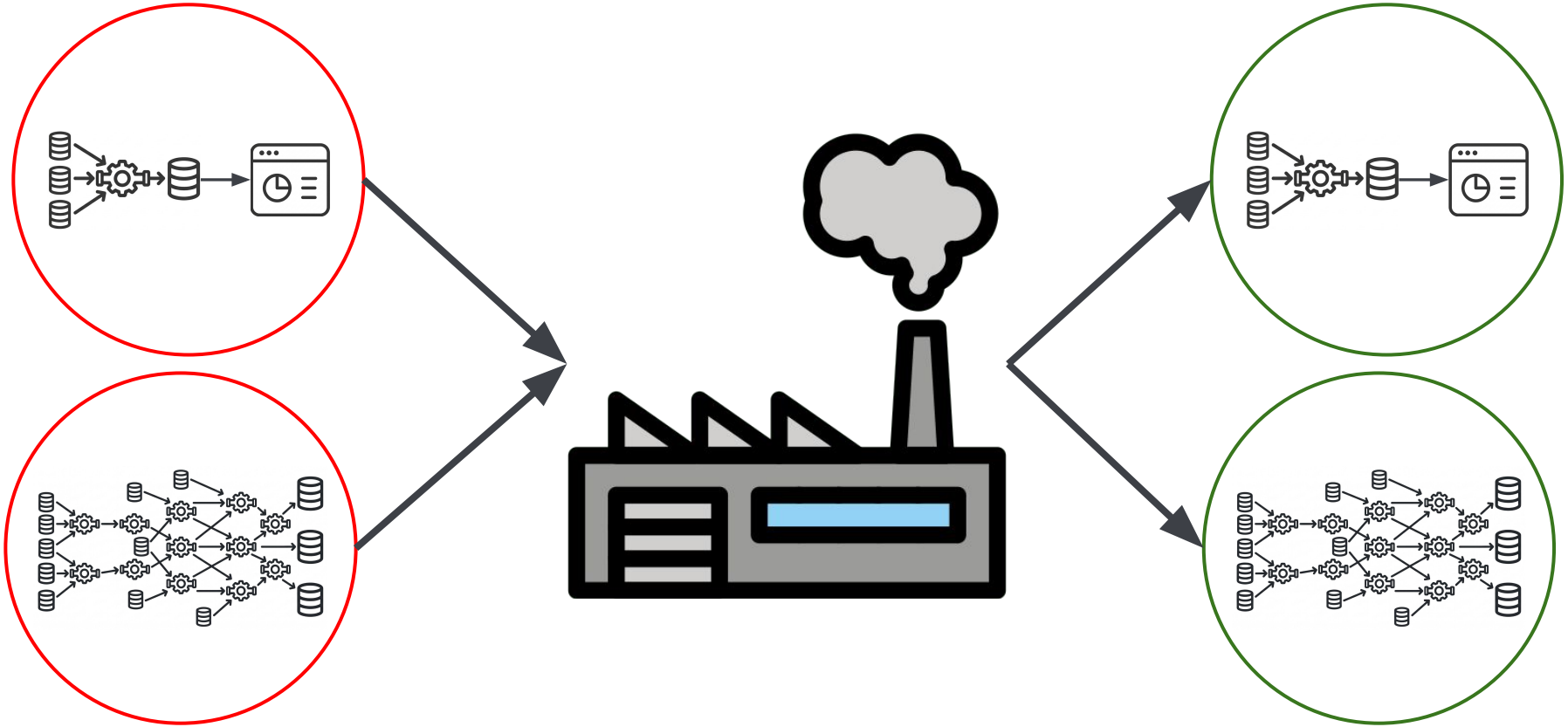

S 2.
S Ex.

Scaling from 5 to 100 teams is easy.

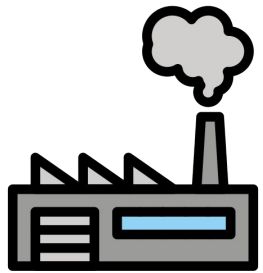
Scaling from 1 team to 5 teams is not.

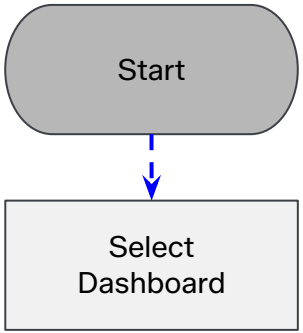


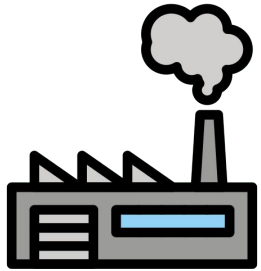


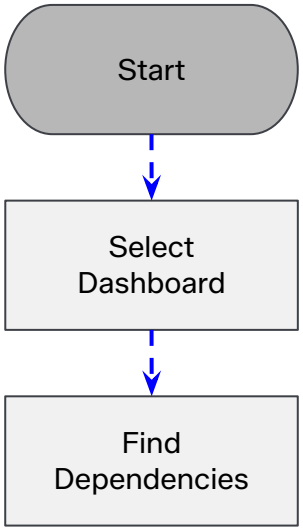


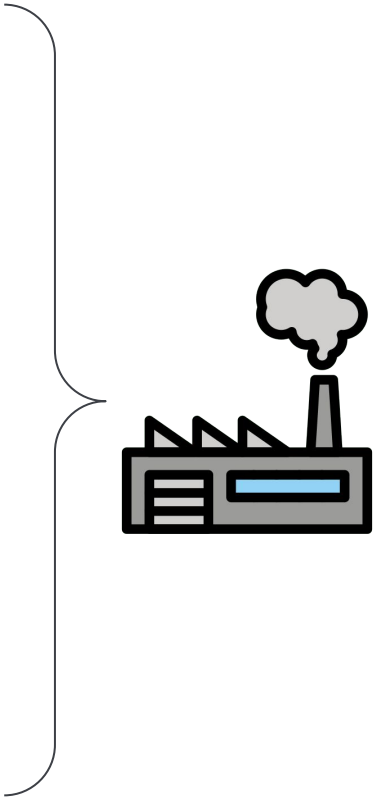
Start

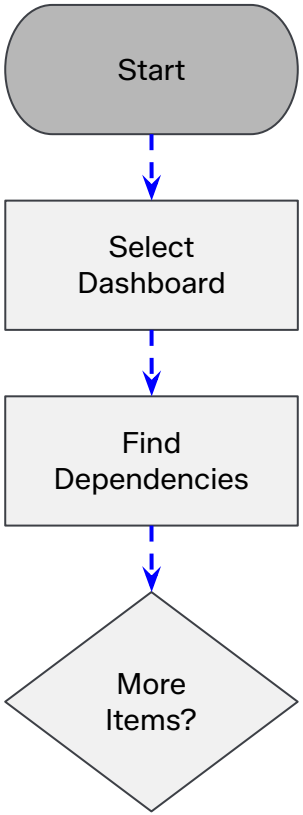


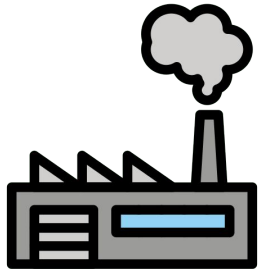

Start
Select
Dashboard

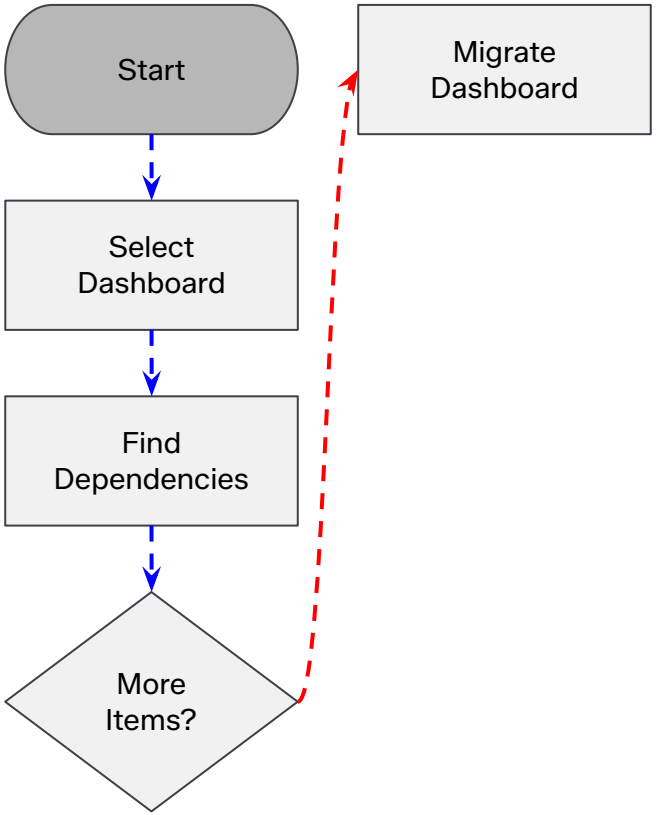


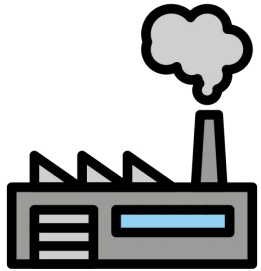

Start
Select Dashboard
Find Dependencies

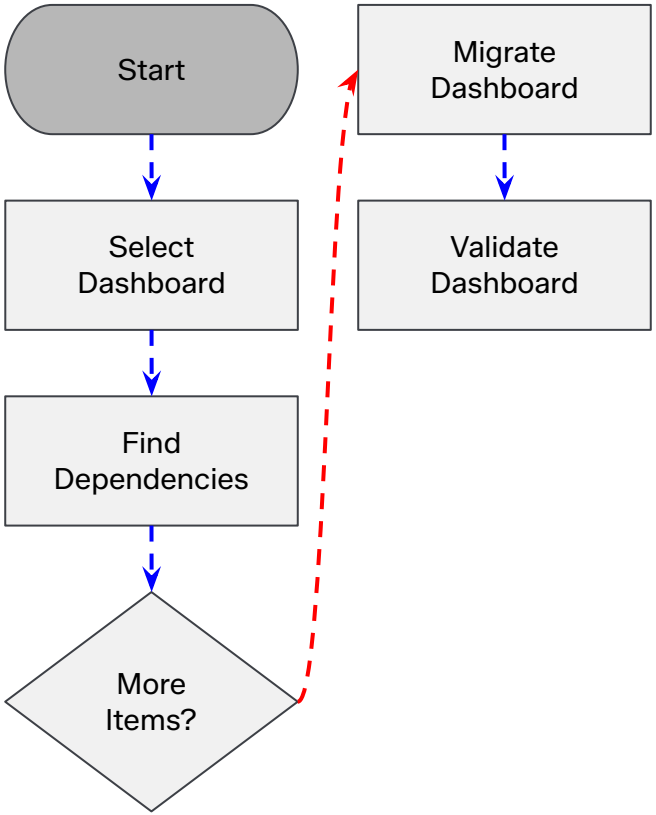


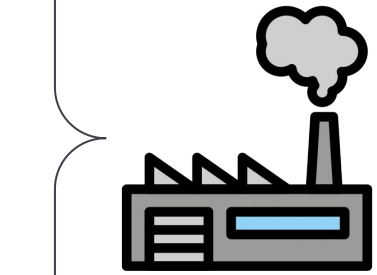

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More Items?

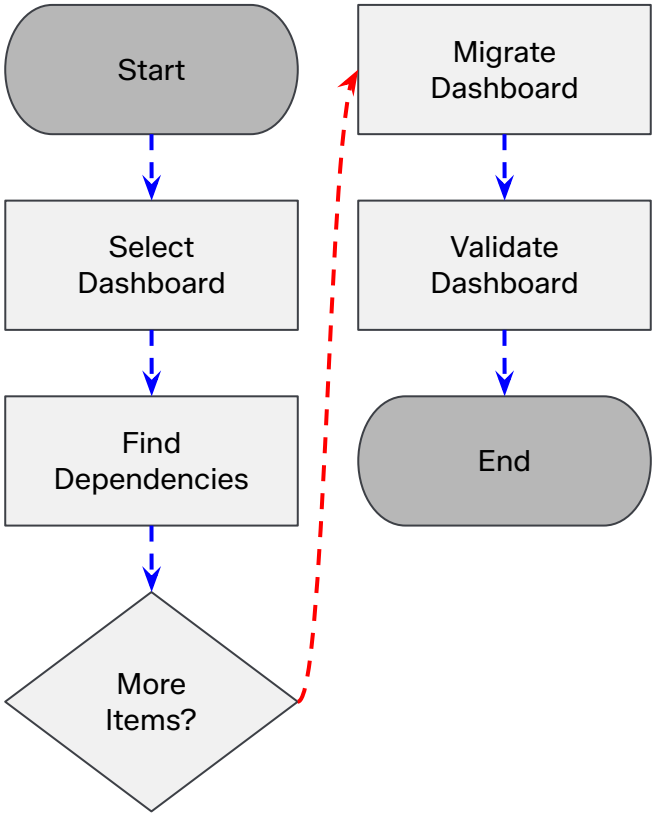


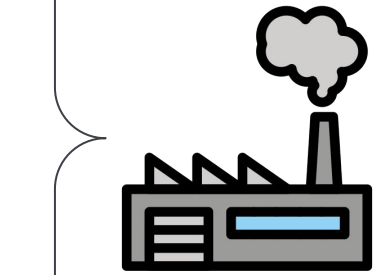

Start
Migrate Dashboard
Select Dashboard
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More Items?

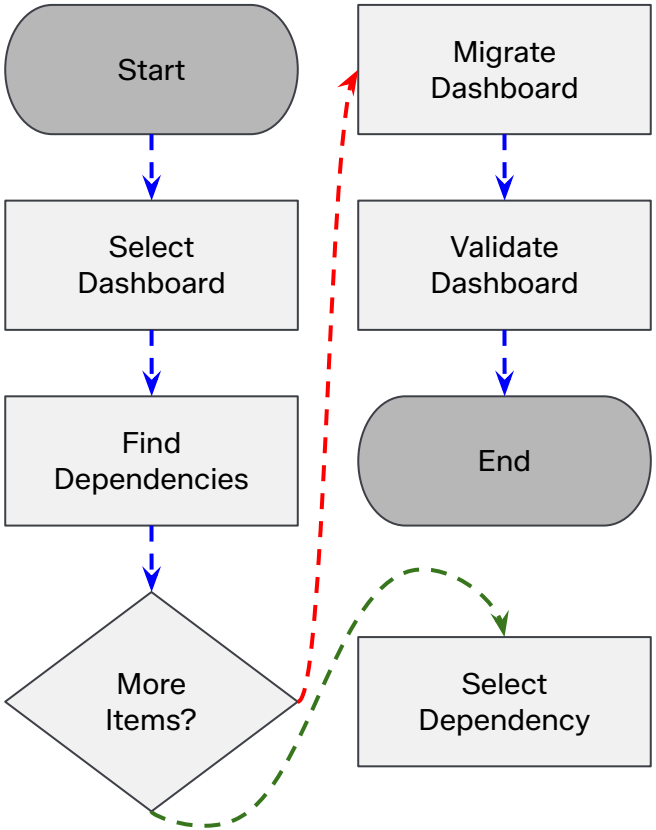


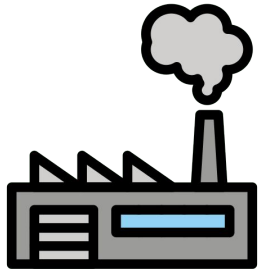

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Validate Dashboard

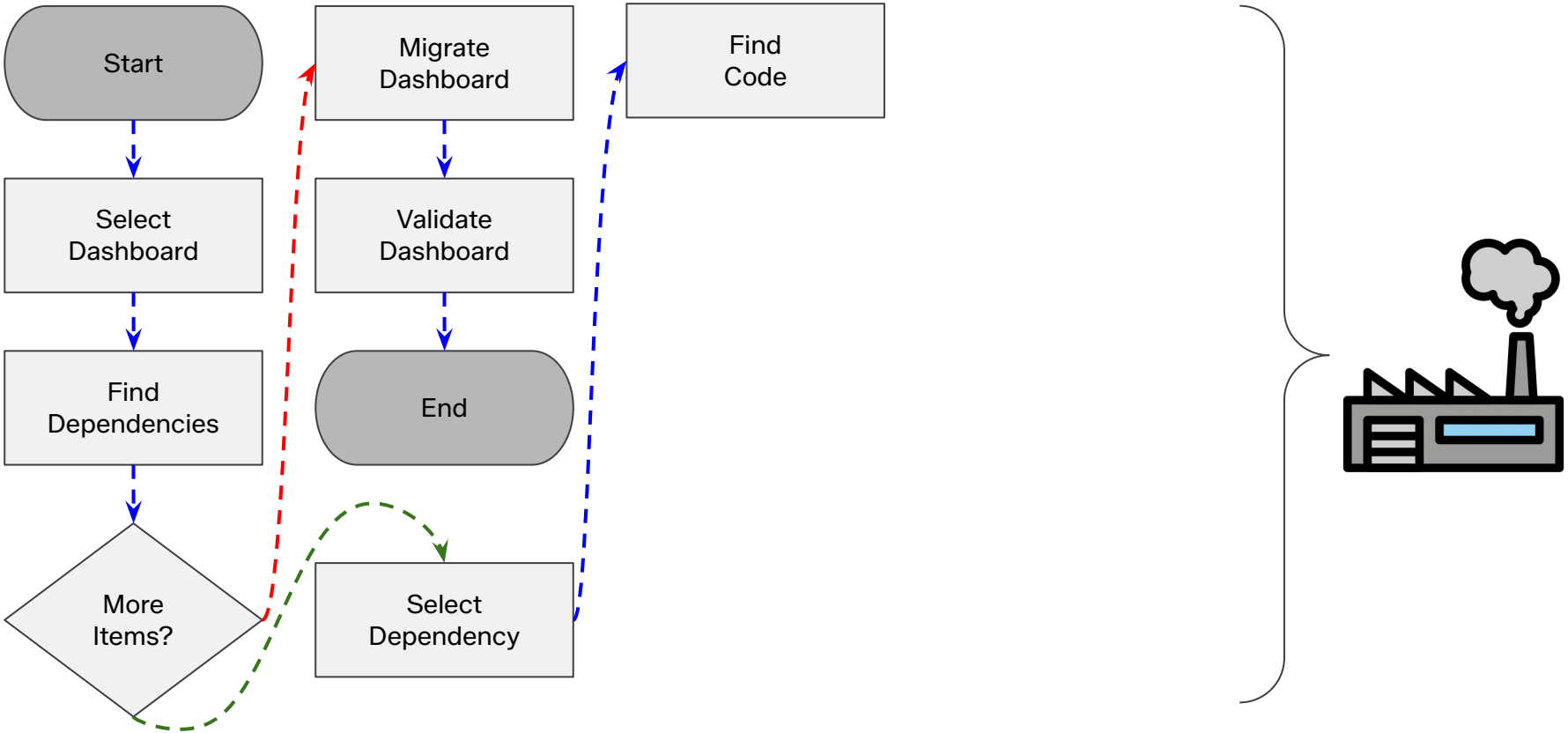


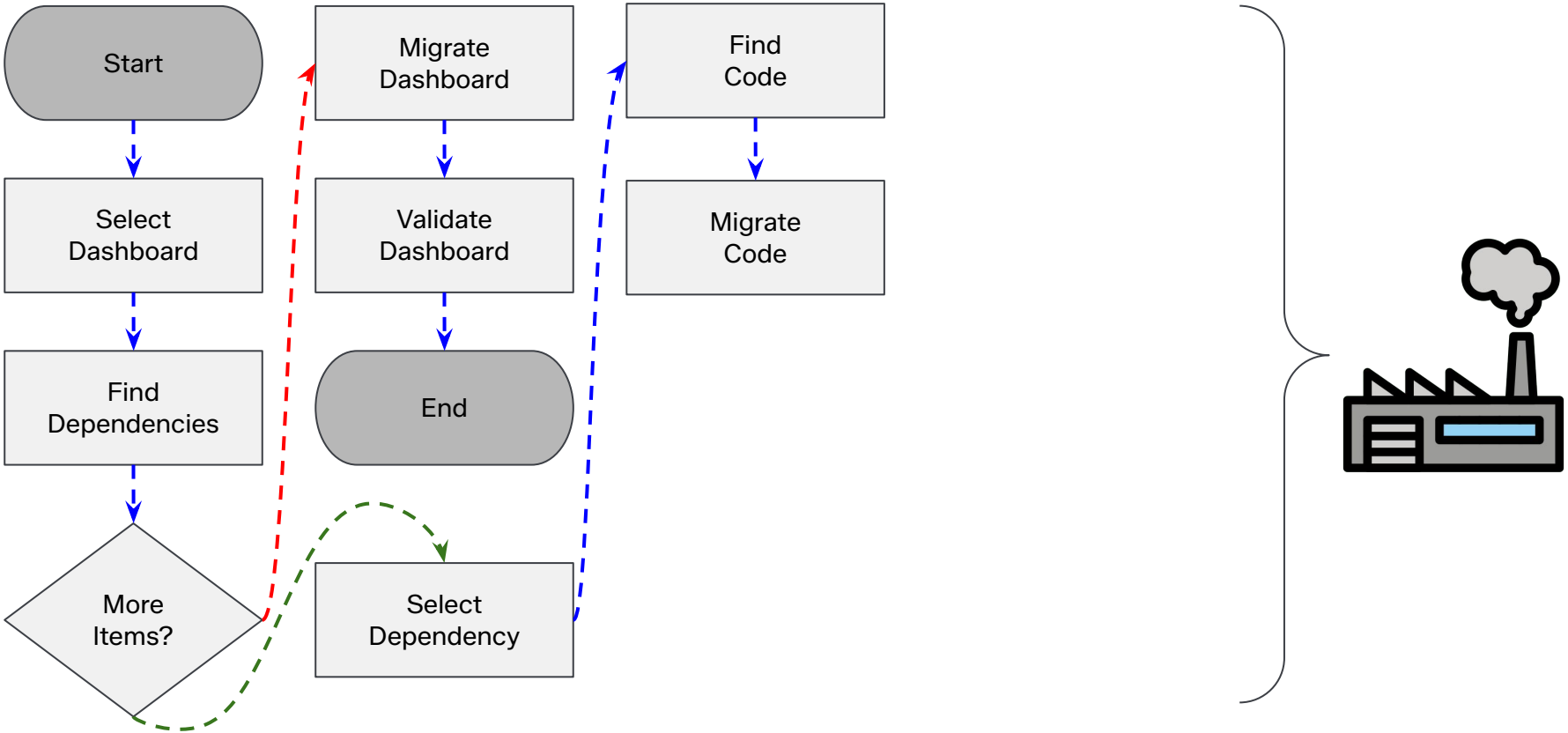

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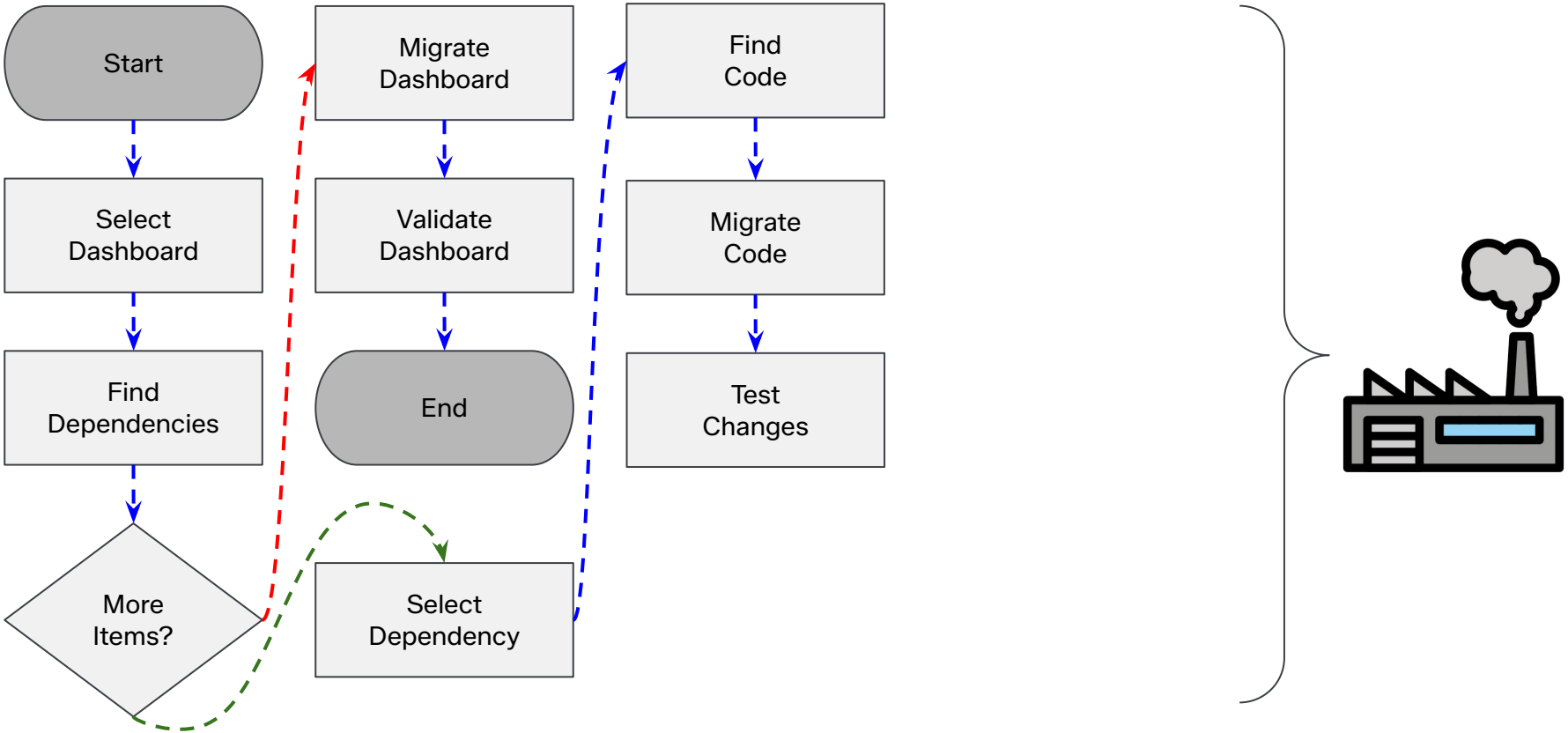


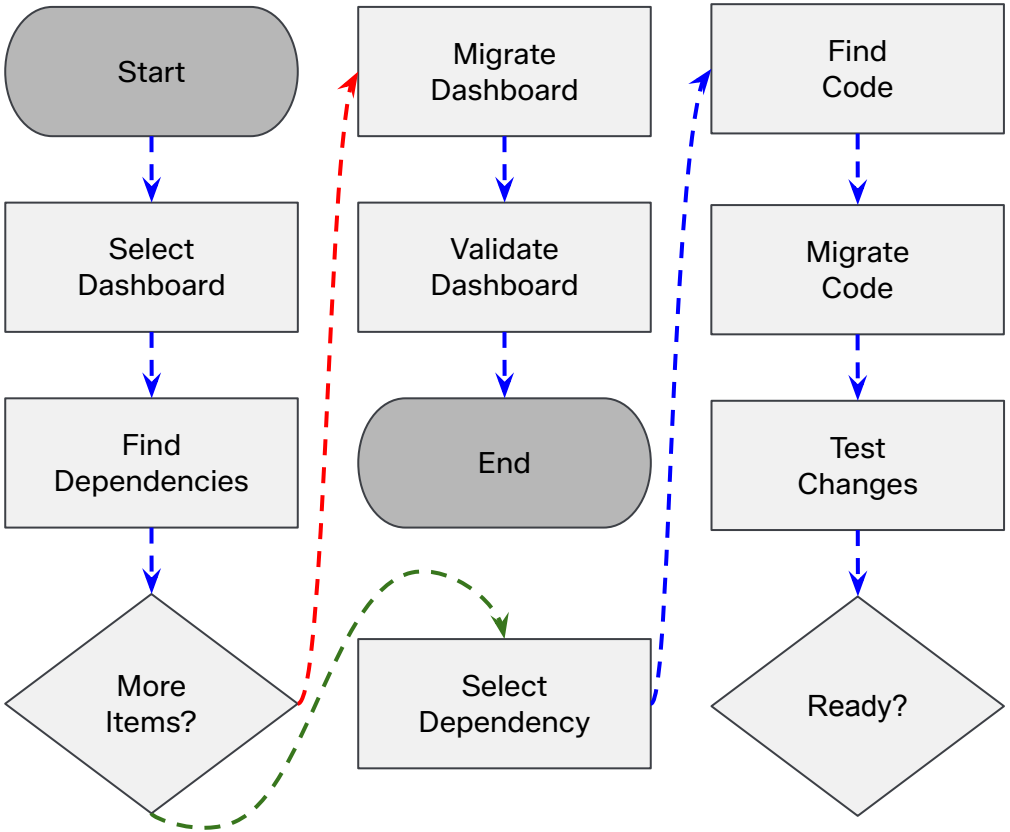

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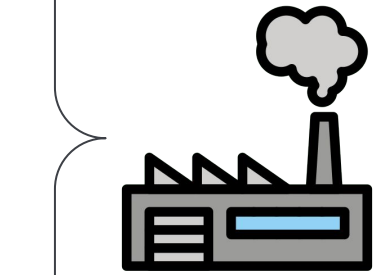


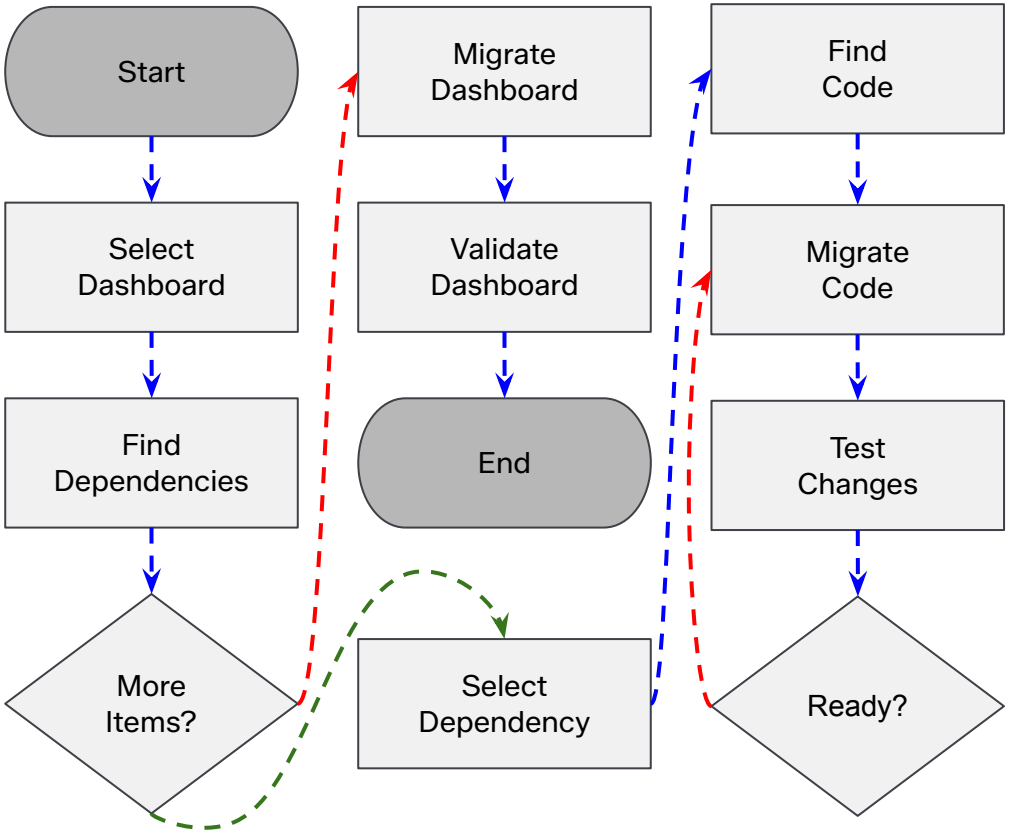

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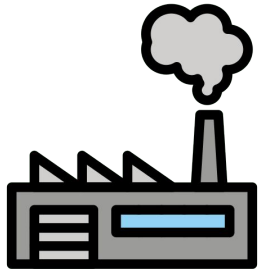

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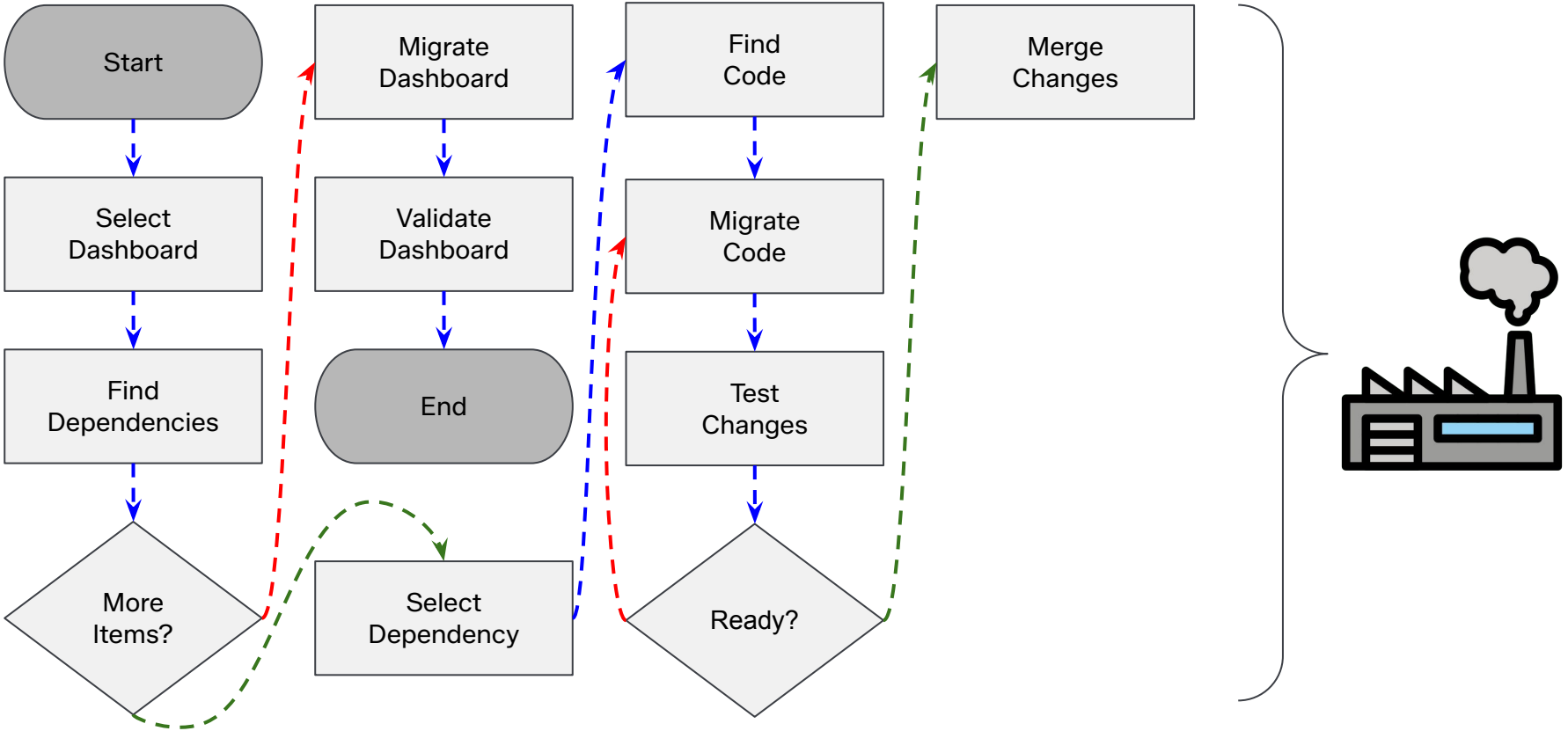

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Select Dependency
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Find Code
Migrate Code
Test Changes

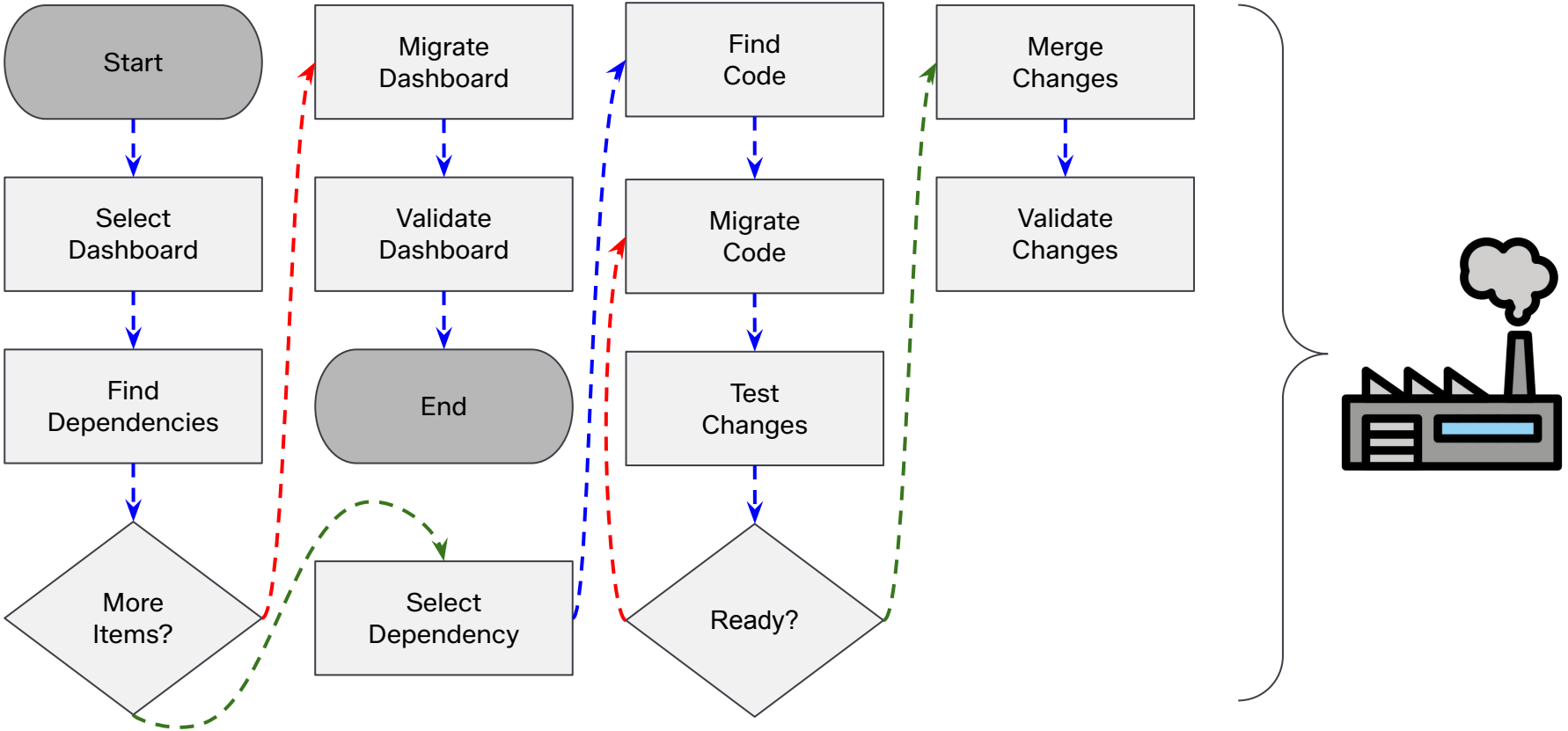

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Test Changes
Ready?

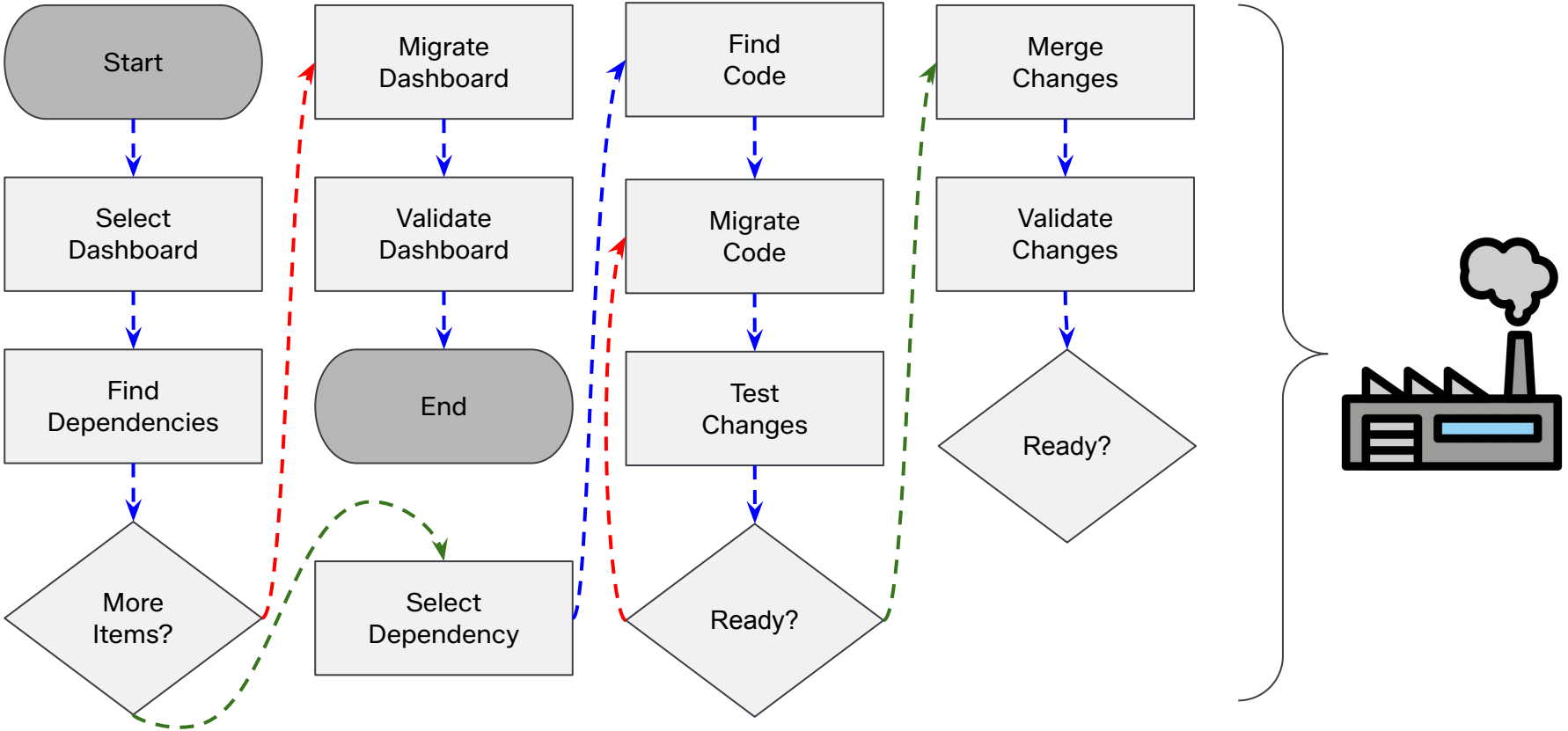


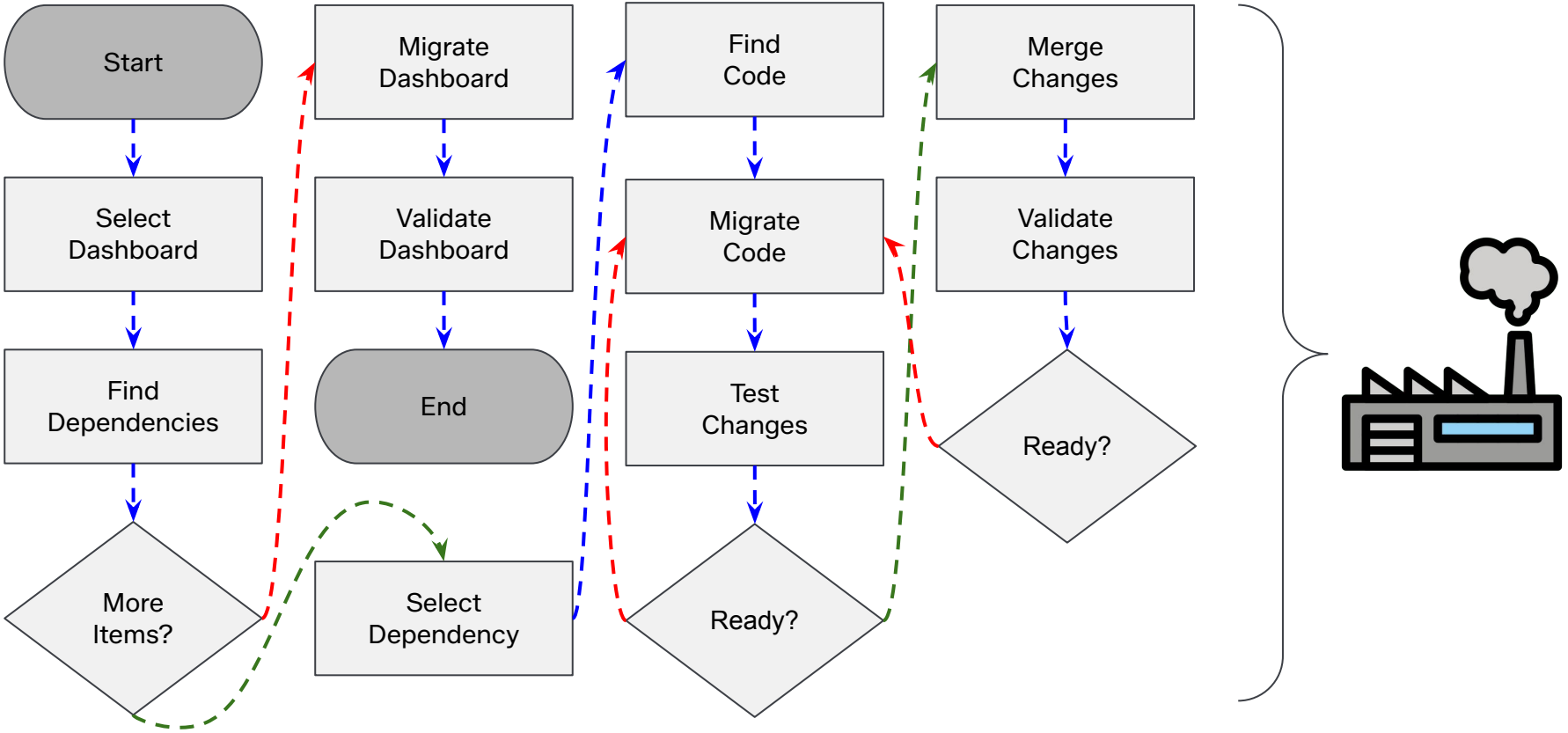

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Select Dependency
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Migrate Code
Test Changes
Ready?

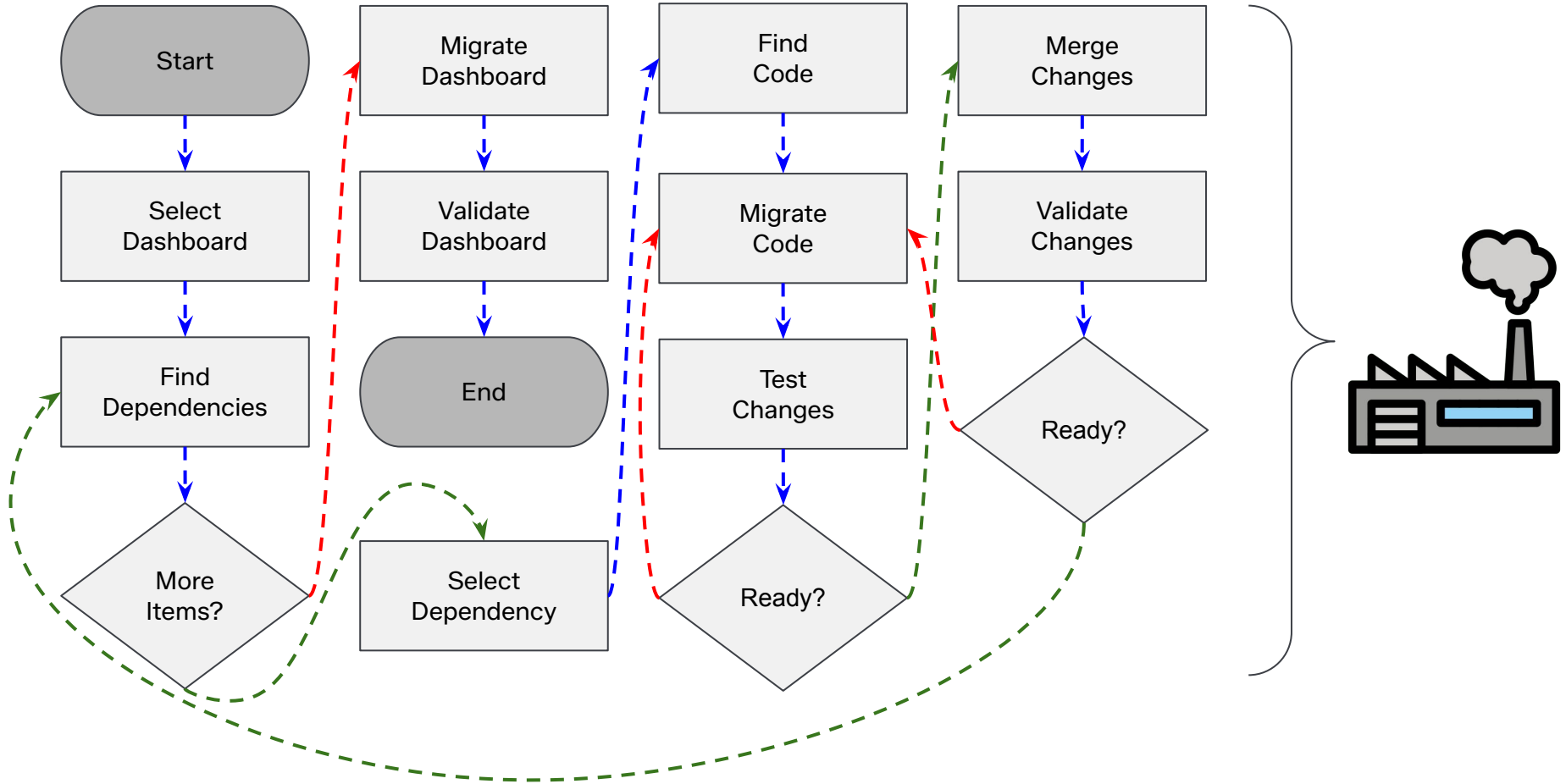


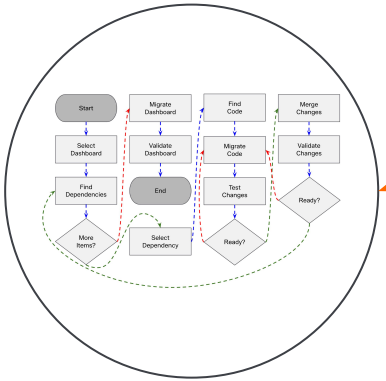

Start
Select Dashboard
Find Dependencies
More Items?
Select Dependency
Migrate Dashboard
Validate Dashboard
End
Find Code
Migrate Code
Test Changes
Ready?
Merge Changes


Start
Select Dashboard
Find Dependencies
More Items?
Select Dependency
Migrate Dashboard
Validate Dashboard
End
Find Code
Migrate Code
Test Changes
Ready?
Merge Changes
Validate Changes

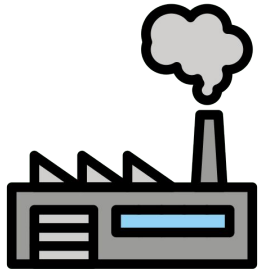

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Validate Dashboard
End
Find Code
Migrate Code
Test Changes
Ready?
Merge Changes
Validate Changes
Ready?

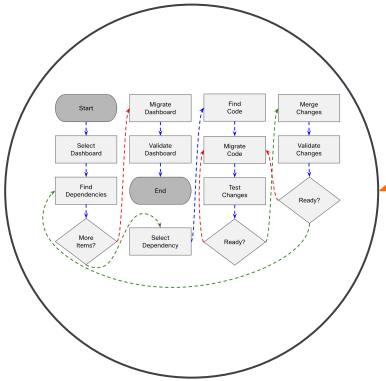

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Merge Changes
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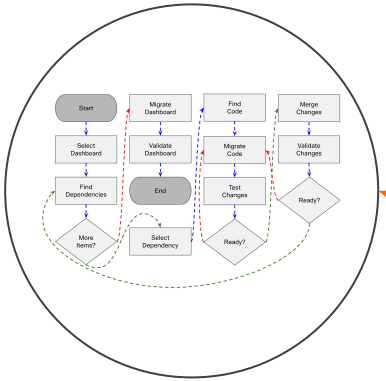

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Validate Changes
Ready?

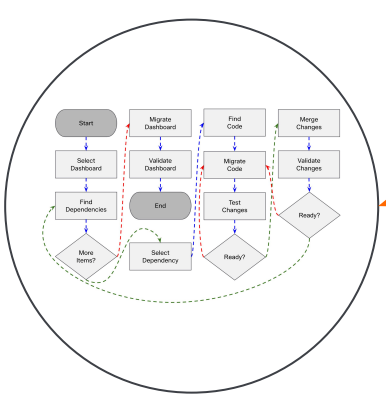

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Migrate Dashboard
Find Code
Merge Changes
Select Dashboard
Validate Dashboard
Migrate Code
Validate Changes
Find Dependencies
End
Test Changes
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More Items?
Select Dependency
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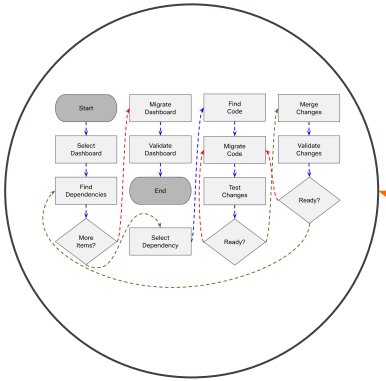


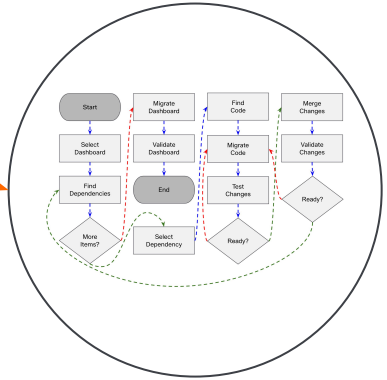


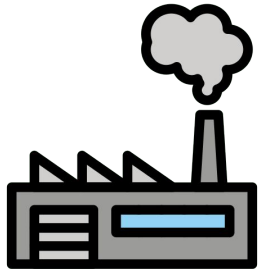

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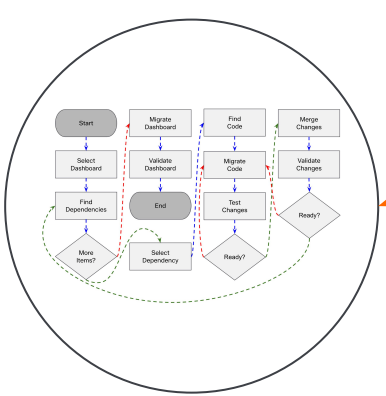

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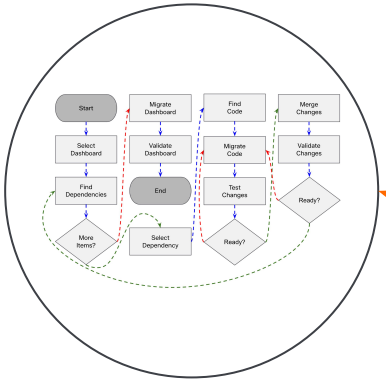

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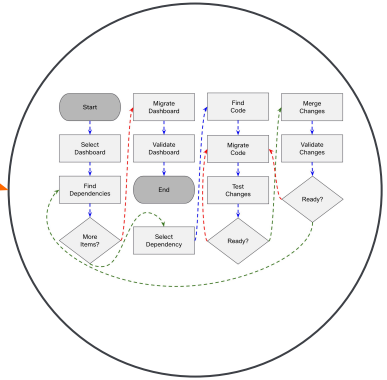

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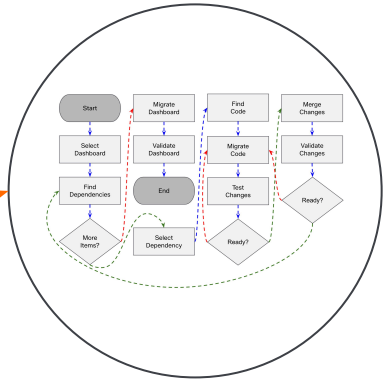

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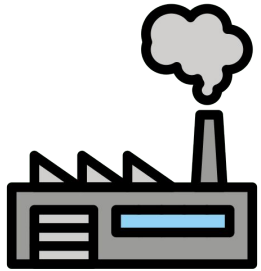


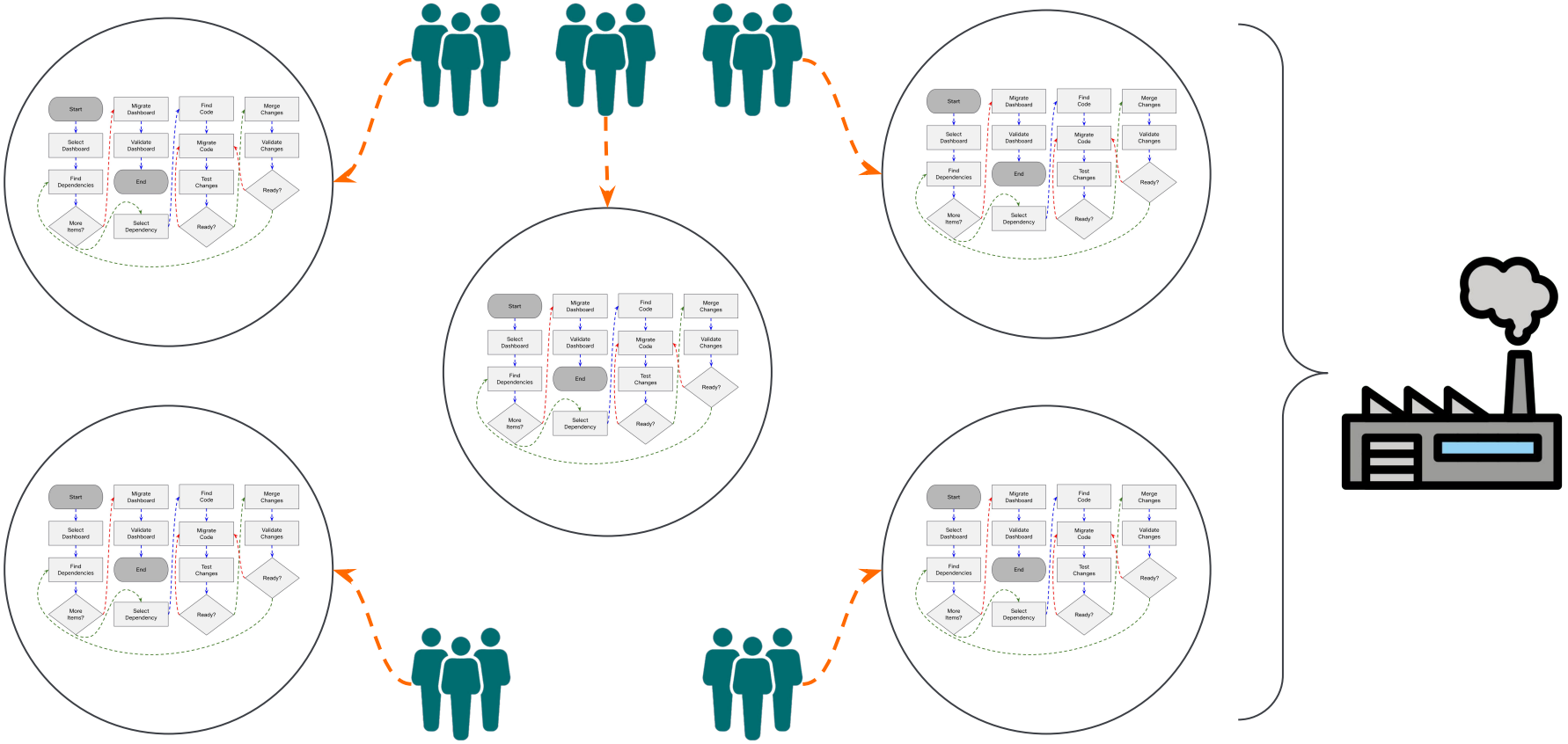

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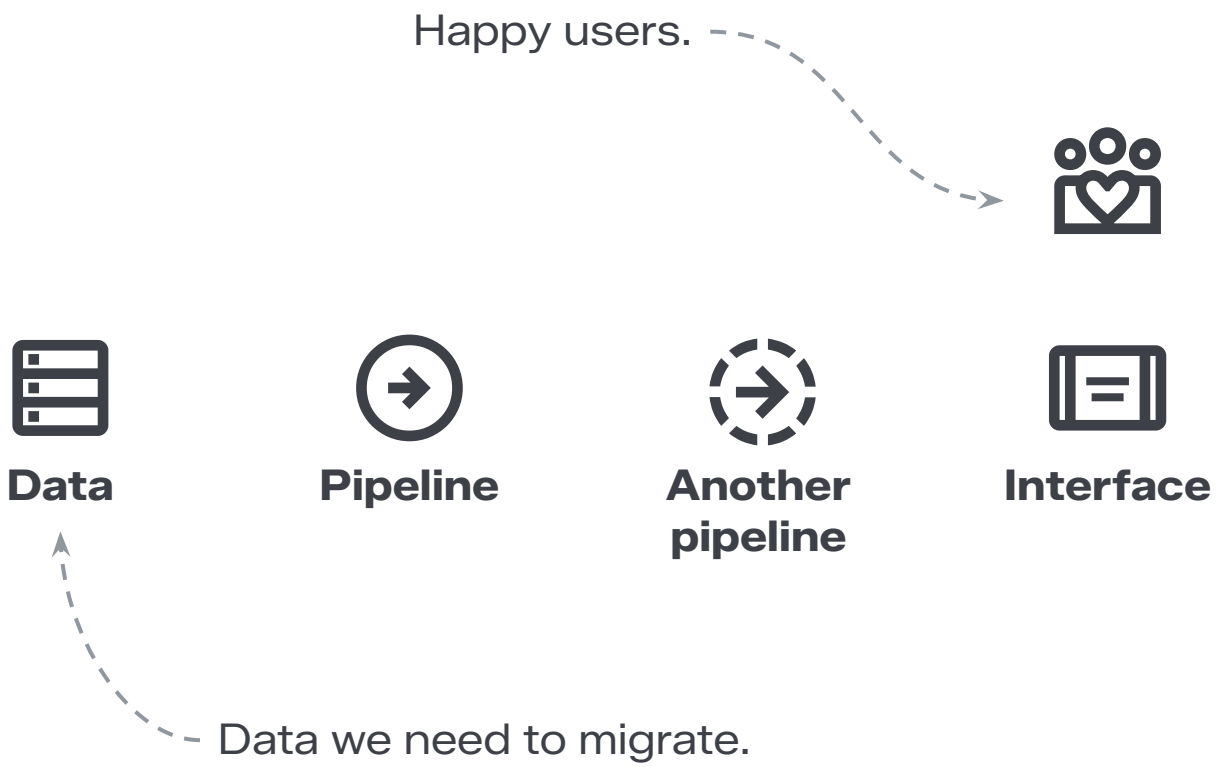

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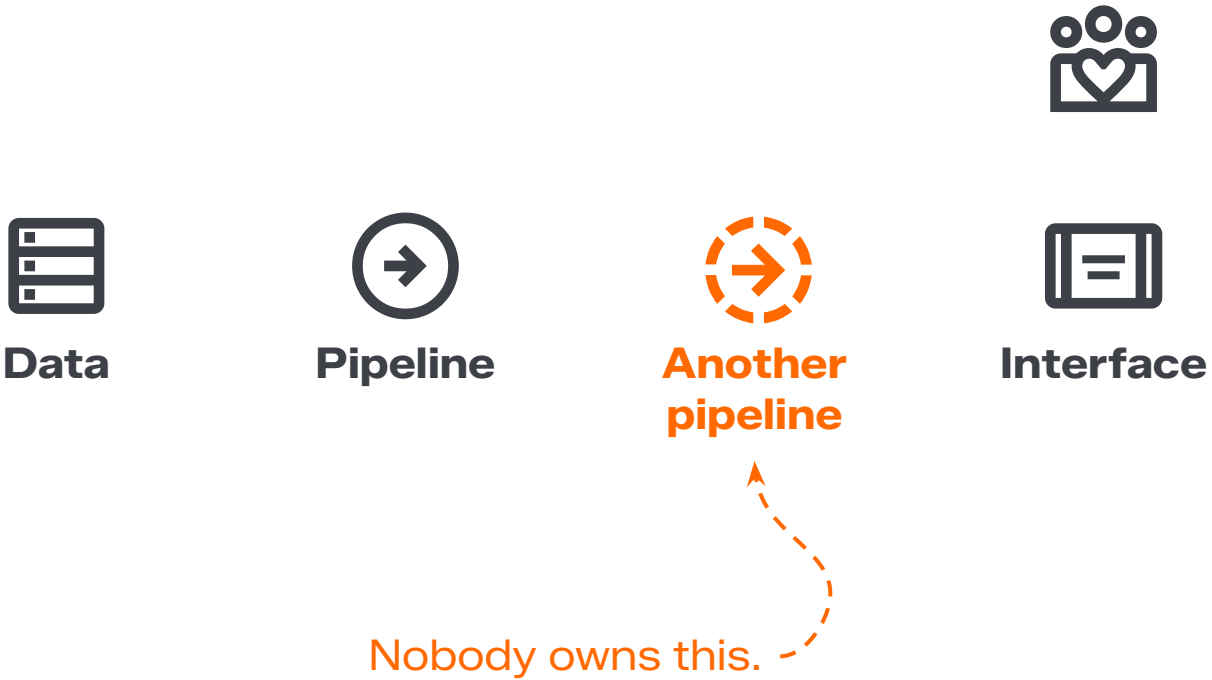

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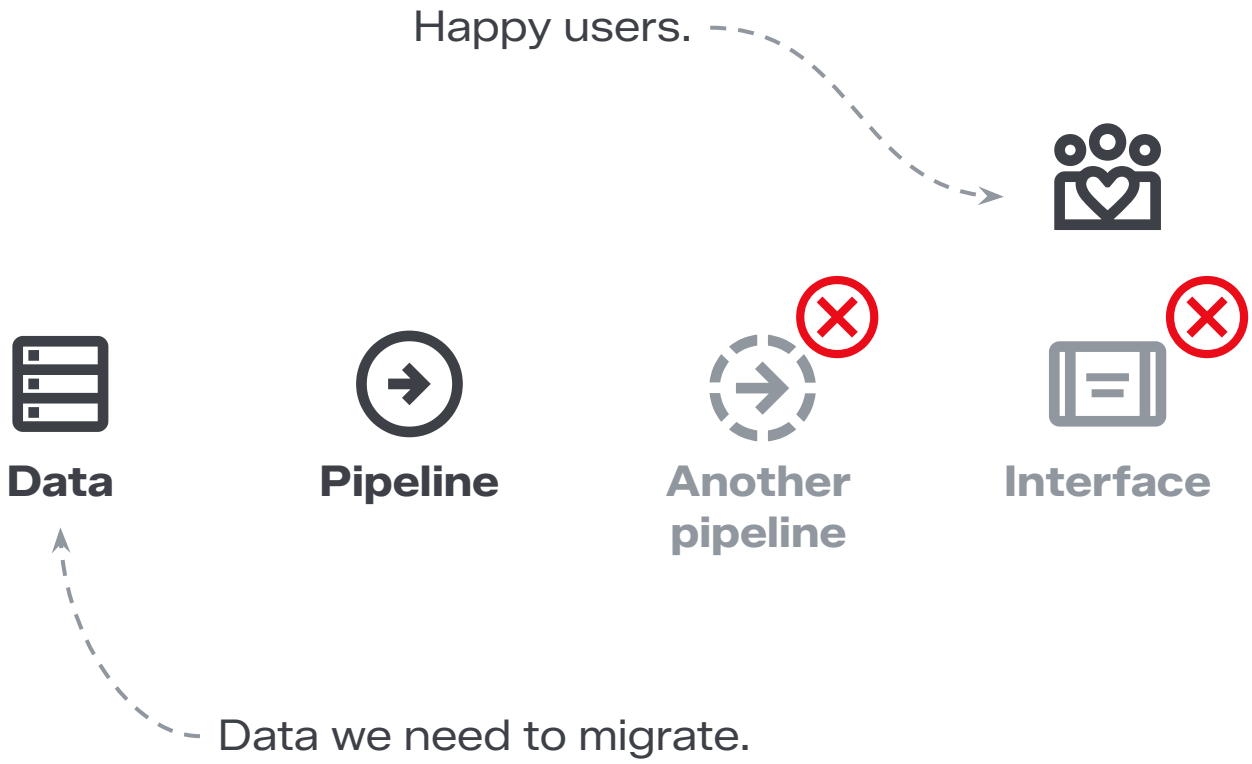

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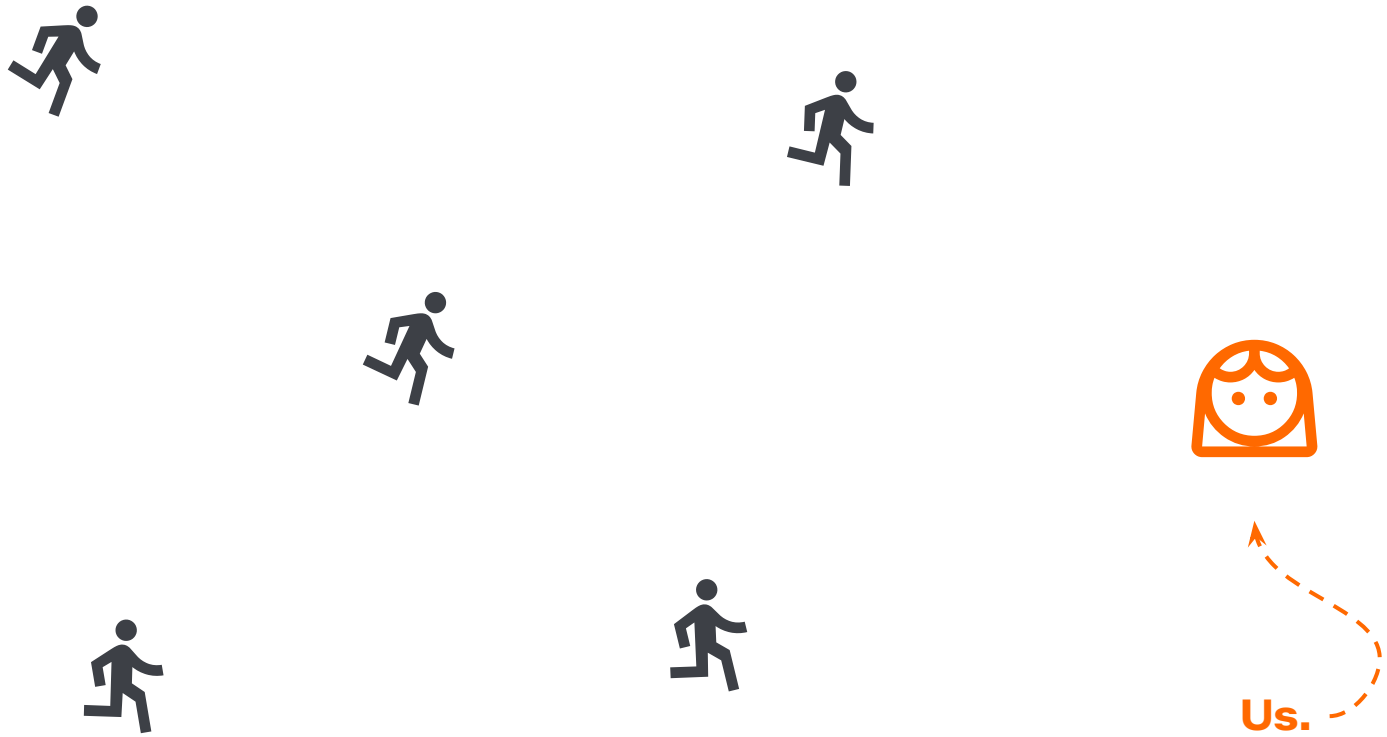
Who owns the unownable?


Happy users.
Data
Pipeline
Another pipeline
Interface
Data we need to migrate.


Data
Pipeline
Another pipeline
Interface
Nobody owns this.

Scream test.


Happy users.
Data
Pipeline
Another pipeline
Interface
Data we need to migrate.


Us.

If you don't own your legacy,

your tech debt will outlive your new architecture.

Company-wide
AI-assisted
migration.

-52%
data infra costs.

Project duration:
12 m → 3 m.

~100
happy teams.

Thank you.

This is Mukrram.



And this is Eugene.

